WORDS WORTH

The middle-life crisis

For a segment that drives India's economy, the middle class is severely stretched and strained **Page 4**

WELL BEING

NEW CHOLESTEROL PILL A GAME-CHANGER?

How a new drug, earlier taken in the form of an injectable, might alleviate the LDL burden in India **Page 9**

FE LINES

Recorder reimagined

Devices today not only record but also transcribe conversations, identify speakers & more **Page 8**

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LEISURE

QUICK BITES FIBREMAXXED

How snacks are embracing the next wave of functional nutrition Page 6

WHAT'S INSIDE

SPOTLIGHT, P5

Longevity comes of age

Changing consumer habits and conversations around ageing, and a rapidly expanding wellness market leading to growing interest in living longer & healthier lives

LIVING, P7

How to assemble the perfect sleep kit

From tech support to wellness products, an entire industry has woken up to give you a good night's rest

PUSHES FOR SELF-RELIANCE, ENERGY SECURITY, TECH PROWESS; BONANZA FOR YOUTH

PM offers 7-step plan for Viksit Bharat

FE BUREAU
New Delhi, August 15

PTI

NARENDRA MODI, PRIME MINISTER

> We must not make the country merely a market for the world; we have to become a hub of innovation

> We can no longer move forward with small dreams. We must dream big

PM Narendra Modi addresses the nation from Red Fort on 80th Independence Day on Saturday

PRIME MINISTER NARENDRA Modi on Saturday unveiled a trove of promises for India's youth, offered more support for the unorganised sector and startups and reaffirmed the government's commitment to making India a developed country by 2047. Addressing the nation from Red Fort on the 80th Independence Day, Modi elaborated on his government's accomplishments, while promising faster economic reforms to strengthen the manufacturing sector, achieve scale and foster greater self-reliance on multiple fronts. He laid emphasis on energy security, especially in light of recent threats from external factors.

Acknowledging that coaching for competitive exams has become "a huge burden for middle-class families", he said the government will provide free online coaching for various examinations to the youth. "We have digital public infrastructure, highly talented teachers and educators. By bringing these resources together, we will provide free coaching to the country's young people and build an entire network for this purpose," he said.

He also announced a new scheme to train 10 million young people in artificial intelligence skills to equip them with the skills necessary to "lead in the world of AI".

Modi highlighted that semiconductors, AI, quantum technology, space, robotics and data centres would drive the economy in the future, adding that India should not become merely a market for new technologies but an 'innovation hub'. While three semiconductor manufacturing units are operational in the country, he said another 5-8 semiconductor plants are expected to be set up in the next 7-8 years.

Modi's 13th straight I-Day speech included a decisive response to the disaffection among the country's youth against the backdrop of ongoing protests over exam paper leaks, and the flashpoint in the national capital which led to the education minister's resignation. The PM mentioned the word 'youth' 21 times in his 75-minute speech and referred to the 'young' 23 times.

Continued on Page 2

PM's PROMISES

- Five-eight more semiconductor plants
- **100 GW** nuclear power capacity by 2047
- Lakhpati Didi target to double to **60 million**
- AI training for **10 million** youth
- Free online coaching for competitive exams
- Talent hunt to identify promising sportspersons

Sapta Dhara framework

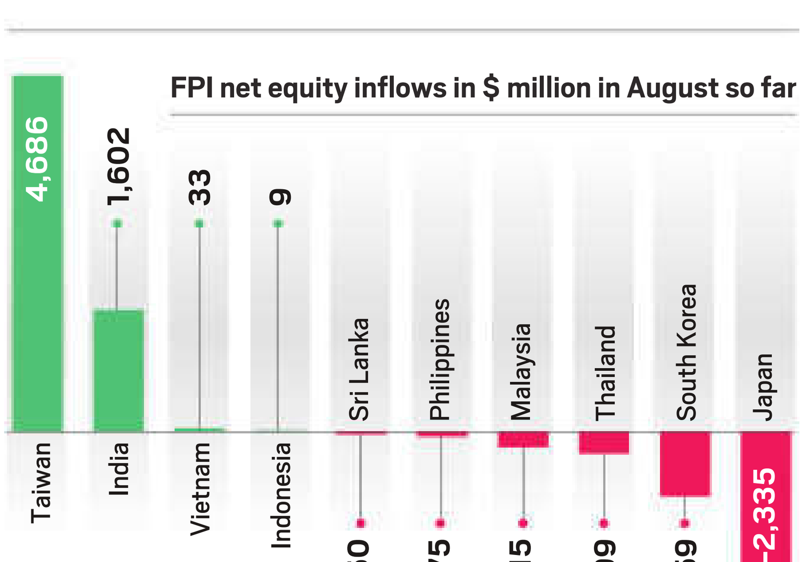
- **Manufacturing:** Enable value chain for small components and large products, from design to manufacturing
- **Agri & food processing:** Farmer access to global markets aided by FTAs, with cuisine, millets, etc
- **Defence:** Emerge as global supplier of next-gen defence tech like drones, hypersonic tech
- **Tech & innovation:** Create hub for emerging tech such as AI, quantum tech, space
- **Green & blue economy:** Global scale in renewable energy, green hydrogen; fisheries, ocean tech
- **Gati Shakti:** High-speed inter-city connectivity via high speed rail; ports to be engines of growth
- **Soft power:** Tap yoga, ayurveda, handicrafts, culture, films, digital content, tourism

»INSIDE« INDIA INC HAILS PM'S GROWTH VISION PAGE 2

India second-biggest recipient of FPI inflows

AFTER ATTRACTING $2.5 billion in FPI (foreign portfolio investors) equity inflows in July, India received another $1.6 billion in August so far, according to data sourced from *Bloomberg*. India was the second-largest recipient of FPI inflows during the period, after Taiwan, which attracted $4.7 billion. In contrast, Japan and South Korea recorded FPI outflows of $2.3 billion and $859 million, respectively.

— **Compiled by Kishor Kadam**



Source: Bloomberg

Limited window to disclose foreign assets and income

SHUBHAM RANA
New Delhi, August 15

THE GOVERNMENT HAS opened a one-time voluntary disclosure scheme for taxpayers to declare their undisclosed or undeclared foreign assets and income. Under the Foreign Assets of Small Taxpayers-Disclosure Scheme (FAST-DS), taxpayers can declare their undisclosed foreign bank accounts, overseas property, jewellery, artistic works, unquoted shares and securities, other assets or undisclosed foreign income on payment of a specified tax or fee.

The Central Board of Direct Taxes (CBDT) on Saturday notified the rules for the scheme, which was announced in the Union Budget 2026 by Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman. The scheme comes into effect from Sunday, with December 31 the last date for filing these declarations.

"This scheme allows taxpayers with non-disclosure of foreign income and assets, up to specified thresholds to regularise their position through a simple, one-time process. Taxpayers with qualifying foreign holdings should evaluate eligibility and act promptly," said Richa Sawhney, partner, tax, Grant Thornton Bharat.

Sitharaman in her Budget speech had said this scheme was aimed at addressing practical issues of small taxpayers such as students, young professionals, tech employees, relocated non-resident Indians.

Continued on Page 2

BROAD CATEGORIES

- First covers undisclosed assets outside India as on March 31, or foreign income not exceeding ₹1 crore
- Second covers foreign assets with aggregate value of up to ₹5 crore
- One-time scheme begins Sunday, ends Dec 31

Windfall tax cut on diesel, petrol and ATF exports

THE CENTRAL GOVERNMENT has lowered the windfall gains tax on exports of petrol, diesel, and aviation turbine fuel (ATF), effective Saturday, said the finance ministry in a notification, reports **Shubham Rana** in **New Delhi**. The windfall tax on diesel exports was cut to ₹24 per litre from ₹25.5 per litre earlier. The duty on ATF comes down by ₹2.5 per litre to ₹19.5 per litre.

Duty on petrol exports has also been reduced to nil from ₹3.5 per litre, as per the notification. "There is no change in the existing excise duty rates on petrol and diesel cleared for domestic consumption," the ministry said.

The government first imposed export duties on diesel and ATF on March 27 to ensure domestic availability of petroleum products by disincentivising exports in the backdrop of the West Asia war and surge in global energy prices. The Centre reviews the rates every fortnight based on international prices of crude oil and petroleum products. Petrol exports were brought under the windfall-tax framework from May 16.

India closer to private nuclear power as draft rules issued

AGENCIES
New Delhi, August 15

Public feedback on draft rules sought by Sept 4

THE COUNTRY MOVED a step closer to opening its nuclear power sector to private investment, with the Department of Atomic Energy issuing draft rules to implement legislation that ends decades of state dominance of the industry.

The rules, issued late Friday, come eight months after nuclear laws were overhauled to attract private firms and investment to the sector. In his Independence Day speech also, PM Narendra Modi said India aims to start five nuclear reactors within six to seven years.

Nuclear plant operators need to maintain an insurance policy, financial security or a combination of both for nuclear damage, as per the draft rules of the Sustainable Harnessing and Advancement of Nuclear Energy (SHANTI) Act, 2025. Released by the Department of Atomic Energy, the draft rules state that the financial security has to remain in place till the removal of all spent fuel from the storage pool concerned. The Centre has to, once every five years, constitute a group of experts to review the maximum limits of an operator's civil liability for nuclear damage.

Continued on Page 2

3-horse race in two-wheeler space

VIKRAM CHAUDHARY
New Delhi, August 15

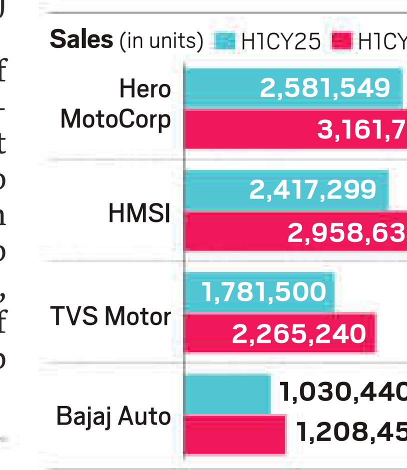
FOR ALMOST TWO decades, Hero MotoCorp and Honda Motorcycle & Scooter India (HMSI) were the undisputed leaders of the two-wheeler market — with HMSI closely trailing Hero — while TVS and Bajaj, both distant, fought for the third position.

But in the first half of this calendar year, TVS has narrowed the gap with Hero and HMSI, and has left Bajaj far behind.

Data from the Society of Indian Automobile Manufacturers (SIAM) shows that TVS's sales grew 27.15% to reach 2,265,240 units in H1CY26, compared to 1,781,500 units in H1CY25, outpacing Hero's growth of 22.48% (3,161,788 units, up from 2,581,549 units).

Continued on Page 2

TVS CLOSING GAP



This festive season to be testy for sweets makers

Under pressure amid regulatory heat, rising costs

VAISHALI DAR
New Delhi, August 15

THE UPCOMING FESTIVE season will not be an easy one for sweets brands amid heightened food safety scrutiny and rising input costs.

Brands such as Khoya Mithai, Ghantewala, Heritage Foods are tightening scrutiny in face of stricter regulatory focus on adulteration, hygiene and food safety by State Food and Drug Administrations (FDAs) and the national regulator, the Food Safety and Standards Authority of India (FSSAI).

Expecting festive sales to grow 15-20%, driven by premium *mithai*, festive gifting and corporate orders, sweet brand Khoya Mithai has strengthened checks on raw-material sourcing and suppliers, batch-level quality checks, storage and temperature monitoring, and sanitation and hygiene audits ahead of the festive season.

"Our teams are regularly trained on food safety and handling protocols. Festive demand can increase production volumes, but our benchmarks remain strong. Every ingredient that goes into our *mithai* has to meet quality standards throughout the year so that consumers do not worry about the safety of what they are eating," said Sid Mathur, co-founder, Khoya Mithai, which is available across India and Dubai.

At Delhi-based Ghantewala, which is also available online, the emphasis is on controlling the quality of core ingredients. "We are closely monitoring consumer preferences and market trends ahead of the festive season," said Pari Jain, creative director, Ghantewala. "We strictly adhere to FSSAI guidelines and update our processes to align with the latest regulatory requirements. We are paying particular attention to *khoya*, milk, dry fruits and other raw materials while managing production in controlled batches. This is significant because festive demand can put pressure on both manufacturing capacity and cold-chain infrastructure," added Jain.

Leading sweets and *namkeen* chain Haldiram's, which holds an estimated 33% market share in India's organised traditional sweets (*mithai*) market, is depending on standardised production and packaging to maintain standards and quality control. "We are confident of delivering a strong percentage growth in festive sales over last year as we balance tradition and evolving tastes," said Mohit Upadhyay, marketing lead, Haldiram's, which is now expanding its business in the US, the Middle East and Europe.

Continued on Page 2

STRONGER CHECKLISTS

- Emphasis on controlling quality of core ingredients and packaging
- Particular attention to *khoya*, milk & dry fruits, among others
- Storage and temperature monitoring, sanitation and hygiene audits
- Sweets & *namkeen* brands to increase prices if raw material costs go up

At least 47 killed in Indonesia quakes

AT LEAST 47 died after an earthquake of magnitude 7.7 struck off eastern Indonesia on Saturday. Hours later, another earthquake of magnitude 6.9 was reported. PAGE 14

Will declare Hormuz US territory: Trump

EVEN AS Iran called on the US to accept defeat, President Donald Trump blasted Tehran as 'very evil' and said 'will be declaring the Hormuz Strait a territory of the US'. PAGE 14

INDEPENDENCE DAY SPEECH UNDER SCANNER

Opposition hits out at PM over *dimaagi naxal* jibe

AGENCIES
New Delhi, August 15

OPPOSITION PARTIES ON Saturday criticised Prime Minister Narendra Modi for his "dimaagi Naxal" remark, saying he should not have used his Independence Day speech for politics, and claimed his pitch on 33% women's reservation in legislatures displayed the ruling BJP's "hypocrisy" after not implementing the quota in the 2024 general elections.

The prime minister urged political parties to rise above differences to help secure 33% reservation for women in legislatures, called upon the youth to take the lead in building a developed India and warned against being misled by "dimaagi Naxals".

The day also saw a row over leaders of opposition in the Lok Sabha and the Rajya Sabha — Rahul Gandhi and Mallikarjun Kharge — not attending the official Independence Day event at the Red Fort. Congress general secretary Jairam Ramesh said the prime minister first attacked his opponents as "urban Naxals" and is now calling them "dimaagi Naxals". Samajwadi Party president Akhilesh Yadav said the Red Fort is not the place from where one should speak lies, and urged the Centre to implement the Women Reservation Bill in the 2027 UP Assembly elections.

Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) president and former Delhi CM Arvind Kejriwal also took a dig at PM Narendra Modi, calling him an "under-confident, nervous and shaky Prime Minister".

CPI(M) General Secretary M A Baby said, "They always wanted to accuse people in the Opposition that they are anti-national. This is a very convenient accusation that they are Maoist in their mind. It is an atrocious allegation." On women's reservation, he said all political parties should press the government to implement the quota in the existing seats, instead of linking it to delimitation.

CPI general secretary D Raja said Modi had chosen to target dissenters even on Independence Day. CPI Rajya Sabha MP P Sandosh Kumar said the government had no justification for holding back the women's quota when all parties supported the legislation. TMC leader Saket Gokhale also accused him of using the Independence Day platform to target his critics.

"Instead of apologising to the youth for using violence and pellet guns on them, Modi is peddling his usual nonsense. Dump the ego, Mr PM. It's not helping," he said.

NCC girls celebrate winning best contingent during Independence Day celebrations in Chandigarh, on Saturday
EXPRESS PHOTO BY KAMLESHWAR SINGH

'Vande Mataram' gets I-Day stage

In a first for Independence Day celebrations, 'Vande Mataram', with the full six stanzas, was rendered at the Red Fort complex during the 79th anniversary of the historic occasion on August 15, followed by the recitation of the national anthem at the grand event. The mega function commemorates 150 years of the enduring legacy of the national song, 'Vande Mataram', as floral decoration on the ramparts depict the national flag at the centre, flanked by 'Vande Mataram' in Hindi. —PTI

CJP launches 'School thik karo' campaign

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
New Delhi, August 15

COCKROACH JANTA PARTY convenor Abhijeet Dipke on Saturday launched the 'School Thik Karo' campaign from his native village in Hingoli district, alleging that poor students suffered due to the government's neglect and demanded capping of fees of private schools.

The Cockroach Janta Part will also undertake a similar movement regarding poor health conditions at public hospitals. Dipke travelled to his native village, Santuk Pimpri, and attended a flag hoisting ceremony on the occasion of Independence Day.

"We have a form comprising a checklist where it can be mentioned whether there are basic amenities available in the school or not. We will gather the data from schools located in Maharashtra and nationwide. Then we will compile the data," he said.

India Inc hails PM's growth vision

AGENCIES
New Delhi, August 15

INDIA INC ON Saturday welcomed Prime Minister Narendra Modi's Independence Day address, saying it looks forward to working with the government to translate his announcements into actionable programmes to boost investment, jobs, innovation and manufacturing.

Chandrajit Banerjee, Director General, CII, said, "As we mark 80 years of Independence, Prime Minister Narendra Modi's address puts people, sustainability and India's global strengths at the centre of our development journey. His call for Atmanirbhar Bharat, Make in India and Vocal for Local reflects our growing confidence to build a self-reliant, future-ready nation, one that has moved from being among the 'Fragile Five' to the world's fastest-growing major economy in just over a decade". The seven-stream "Sapta Dhara" framework provides a broad-based approach to inclusive, sustainable and accelerated development,

INDUSTRY THUMBS UP

- Sapta Dhara framework to provide sustainable and accelerated development
- Commitment to 7-8 new semiconductor plants
- Entrepreneurial potential in India

Assocham President Nirmal Kumar Minda said. He also said the emphasis on self-reliance, 'Vocal for Local', domestic manufacturing and strategic capabilities is highly significant for strengthening India's economic resilience. Minda said that the PM's Independence Day vision provides strong confidence to Indian industry and the wider business community. Pankaj Mohindroo, chairman, India Cellular & Electronics Association (ICEA), said the PM's commitment to adding five to eight semiconductor plants over the next seven to eight years marked a significant shift in India's technology ambitions. "The bold commitment to 7 to 8 new semiconductor fabs signals an unequivocal move from assembly-line dependence to a leadership position at the heart of global technology manufacturing," he said.

Adani Group Chairman Gautam Adani described the first edition of Vande Bharatam as a reminder of India's vast entrepreneurial potential. In a post on X, Adani said, "The first edition of Vande Bharatam is over. For me, on this Independence Day there is no better reminder of what India is capable of. 26,000+ applications. Every state represented. Young founders, women entrepreneurs, rural innovators and remarkable problem-solvers from Tier 2 and 3 Bharat.... India's next generation of builders is already here. We just need to find them, back them and give them a platform. Happy Independence Day. Jai Hind," he added.

Global leaders back stronger ties with India

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
New Delhi, August 15

INDIA'S GLOBAL PARTNERS, including France, Russia, Australia and the US on Saturday extended greetings to the country on its 80th Independence Day.

French President Emmanuel Macron, Russian President Vladimir Putin and Australian Prime Minister Anthony Albanese were among leaders who

US Secretary of State Marco Rubio

Russian President Vladimir Putin

hailed ties with India on the occasion. Putin greeted his Indian counterpart Droupadi Murmu as well as Prime Minister Narendra Modi, expressing confidence that the constructive bilateral partnership will help enhance international security and stability. Australian PM Albanese also conveyed his greetings on the occasion.

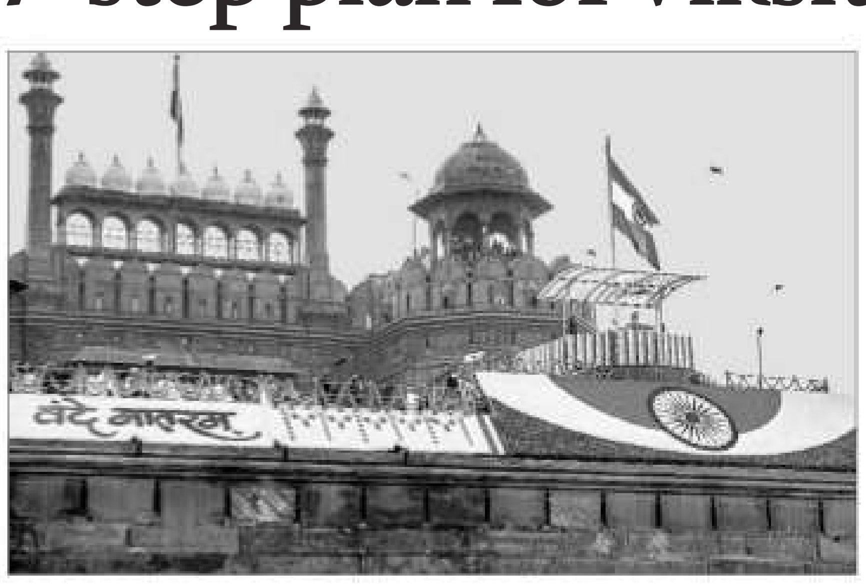
US Secretary of State Marco Rubio greeted the people of India on its 80th Independence Day, asserting that bilateral ties were "stronger than ever" due to the personal relationship between President Donald Trump and Prime Minister Narendra Modi.

FROM THE FRONT PAGE

PM offers 7-step plan for Viksit Bharat

LAMENTING INDIA'S DISMAL record in global sporting events like the Olympics, the Prime Minister said a talent hunt will be launched among children in the age group of 5-15 years to train them to be sports people ready to face global competition. "We have decided that we want the 2036 Olympics to be held in Bharat," he said.

He said while the target of making 30 million 'Lakhpati Didis' had already been surpassed, another 30 million women would be added, signifying a transformation in the rural economy. He reiterated the target of 100 giga watt nuclear power capacity by 2047, with five reactors to be built in a decade, and referred to the recently announced ₹85,000-crore scheme to accelerate offshore exploration, including areas earlier designated as 99% 'no-go' zones. He said India could no longer move with 'small dreams' and called for a fundamental change in its work culture, thinking and pace of execution to meet the 2047 target. Modi said reforms would remain central to this transformation, describing them as "neither a compulsion for us nor a buzzword" but a "matter of conviction".



The Prime Minister outlined a seven-fold economic strategy covering manufacturing, agriculture and food production, technology and innovation, infrastructure and connectivity, defence, the green and blue economy, and India's soft power. Manufacturing, he said, would have to move beyond assembling goods to creating complete domestic value chains. "From design to manufacturing, India must become a trusted centre of the global supply chain," Modi said, adding that quality would have to become a key component of India's global brand.

Defence was identified as another area where India needed to reduce dependence on imports. He called for greater focus on drones, counter-drone systems and hypersonic defence technologies. Setting out longer-term ambitions, Modi asked why India should not have 50 companies among the Fortune 500 within the next decade and at least one Indian bank among the world's top five, indicating a plan to push merger of public sector banks. He also called for Indian pharmaceutical, technology, consulting and accounting firms to aspire for global leadership.

"We must enhance our own capacities and protect our own interests ourselves," Modi said, stressing that self-reliance was essential in a world increasingly shaped by geopolitical and economic disruptions.

He called upon the Centre, states, industry and citizens to work together, saying the developed India ambition could not be achieved by the government alone.

3-horse race in 2-wheeler space

TVS ALSO OUTPACED HMSI's 22.39% growth (2,958,638 units, up from 2,417,299 units), and was far stronger than Bajaj's 17.28% (1,208,459 units, up from 1,030,440 units).

Automotive analysts told *FE* that unlike Hero that is phenomenal in 100-125-cc motorcycles and HMSI that is dominant in scooters, TVS is performing well across segments — the Jupiter family in automatic scooters, the 125-cc Raider in entry-level motorcycles, the Apache range in performance bikes, and the iQube, which is the top-selling electric scooter in India.

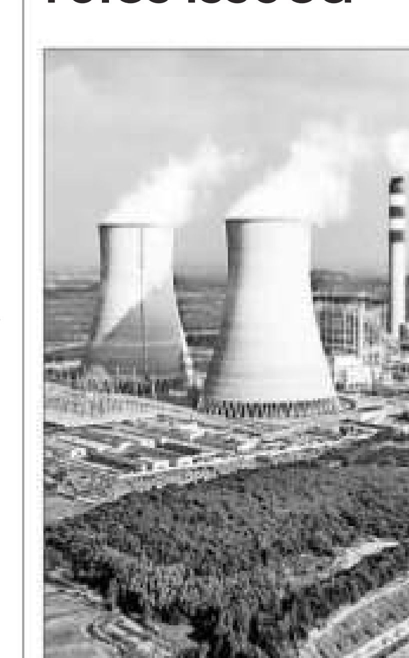
In terms of numbers, while TVS added 483,740 extra units to its kitty in H1CY26, Bajaj could manage just 178,019 units, making TVS almost twice as big as Bajaj. While Bajaj maintains a strong position in international markets and performance motorcycles such as the Pulsar range, its slower domestic momentum stems from its strategic choice to stay out of the high-volume petrol scooter segment, relying instead purely on its Chetak EV.

"What we are witnessing in H1CY26 is the culmination of TVS's segment-wide performance," an analyst covering the auto sector from one of the Big 4 consulting firms said. "While Hero remains anchored to mass-market commuter bikes, and Honda relies heavily on the Activa brand, TVS is growing aggressively across all four major pillars — scooters, 125-cc commuters, premium bikes, and EVs. By capturing urban premiumisation alongside rural demand through models like the Raider and Jupiter, TVS has unlocked a growth rate that separates it from Bajaj and brings it into the slipstream of the top two."

But can TVS challenge Hero and HMSI? Analysts said that while its growth rate is the highest in the industry, catching Hero or HMSI remains a steep upward climb in the near term. The current half-yearly gap between TVS and HMSI stands at 693,000 units, while the gap to Hero is 896,000 units. But TVS's 3-5-year trajectory can pose a genuine threat to Hero and HMSI. "As electric adoption and scooterisation accelerate in semi-urban and urban centres, TVS's early dominance with the iQube and Jupiter positions it to capture market share directly from Hero's traditional commuter base," the analyst said. "In addition, the runaway success of the Raider 125 has allowed TVS to capture younger buyers entering the motorcycle market, a segment where Hero's Splendor brand faces generational ageing."

While Hero MotoCorp and HMSI retain vast rural distribution networks that keep them out of immediate reach, TVS is establishing itself as a permanent member of the top-tier cluster, transforming India's two-wheeler industry into a three-horse race.

India closer to private nuclear power as draft rules issued



ANOTHER KEY PROVISION is that if a nuclear power plant or reactor is of a foreign design, its design should be certified or approved in the country of origin by its regulatory body. Country of origin means countries that are self-reliant in nuclear reactor design and supply-chain ecosystem, whose regulatory approvals are trusted globally.

Such a nuclear power plant or reactor should also be operational either in the country of origin or any other foreign country.

Moreover, the draft rules highlight that the licensing authority may grant "in-principle approval" after admitting an application, where the site or technology has not been selected.

"Upon receipt of a valid 'in-principle approval', the applicant may proceed with negotiation with reactor technology vendors and for acquiring the land and other necessary infrastructure," the draft rules say.

They also mention that there will be a single composite licence authorising the building, owning, operating and decommissioning of the nuclear power plant or reactor.

"No licence shall be applied for, granted, divided, or severed ... in respect of any of those activities separately," the draft rules say.The government has sought public feedback on the draft rules and regulations by September 4.
—BLOOMBERG/PTI

Limited window to close foreign assets

THERE ARE TWO broad categories of declaration under the scheme. The first category covers undisclosed assets located outside India as on March 31, or undisclosed foreign income not exceeding ₹1 crore. Under this category, taxpayers will have to pay a tax of 30% of the value assets or income declared, and another 30% as penalty. The second category covers foreign assets with an aggregate value of up to ₹5 crore. Here, taxpayers can settle the disclosure by paying a fee of ₹1 lakh.

After electronic verification of the voluntary declaration, the income-tax authority will communicate the amount payable by way of an order within one month from the end of the month in which the declaration was made.

The amount must be paid within two months from the end of the month in which the order is received, the ministry said. The scheme does not apply for income or assets, which directly or indirectly represent proceeds of crime where proceedings have been initiated, or are pending, under the Prevention of Money-laundering Act, 2002, the ministry said.

It also does not apply for any income or asset relating to an assessment year for which assessment proceedings have already been completed under the Black money (Undisclosed Foreign income and assets) and Imposition of tax Act, 2015. The ministry has fixed March 31 2026 as valuation date for the scheme. The ministry has also prescribed valuation methods for foreign bank accounts, bullion and jewellery, immovable property, archaeological collections, shares and securities.

After the payment for settlement of disclosure is completed, along with other condition, the taxpayer will be granted immunity from levy of any further tax or penalty and prosecution for any offence under the Black Money Act, of 2015.

This year's festive season to be testy for sweet makers

HYDERABAD-BASED HERITAGE Foods, which offers festive products such as *doodh peda* and *laddoos*, is preparing for higher festive demand by ramping up *ghee* production and adding new facilities. "We are careful about the quality of ingredients, supplier controls, testing, hygiene and storage conditions of our khoya-based products. We see increased regulatory scrutiny from FSSAI and authorities like the Maharashtra FDA as a positive development for the industry. Stronger enforcement and greater adherence to standards improve quality, while giving consumers greater confidence in the products they purchase. For an organised dairy company, maintaining proper sourcing, cold-chain processes, testing and handling becomes even more important when demand for milk and dairy ingredients rises sharply during festivals," said Srideep Kesavan, CEO, Heritage Foods.

Rising milk prices and shortage during high demand season is another challenge."Higher raw material costs do put pressure on margins and may require selective price revisions, which we try and absorb as much as possible," said Meerra Singh, co-founder, Delhi and Gurugram-based Akhand Sweets. The impact can be significant. "One kg of *khoya*-based *mithai* uses approximately 700g *khoya*, 200g sugar, 50-80g *ghee* and 80-100g dry fruits. Even a moderate increase in price can push costs up by 10-15%," said Singh, adding that festive packaging and gifting adds to costs further.

"If prices of raw materials go up, we will be forced to revise prices rather than compromising on the quality of ingredients," said Jain of Ghantewala, whose sweet shop is famous for *sohan halwa*. As for Heritage Foods, "For an organised dairy company, maintaining robust sourcing, cold-chain, testing and handling practices becomes more critical when demand for milk and dairy ingredients rises sharply during festivals. This becomes important in the current environment, with average milk procurement costs increasing 7.2% YoY to ₹46.61 per litre in Q1 FY27, reflecting continued industry-wide milk inflation," said Kesavan. In Maharashtra, cow and buffalo milk prices rose by ₹2 per litre this month, taking buffalo milk to ₹78 per litre. The Milk Producers and Processors Welfare Association attributed the increase to higher procurement costs, a ₹10-per-litre rise in diesel prices and an estimated 30% increase in packaging costs. Dairy product prices are expected to further rise by up to 10%. In May, Amul and Mother Dairy raised milk prices by ₹2 per litre across Delhi-NCR and north India.

"Dairy prices affect us significantly as butter, cream and milk are integral to a large part of our production. Even a relatively small increase has an impact when you are working at festive volumes," said Natasha Pereira, co-owner and marketing head, Toujours, a Mumbai-based online-first patisserie. Even as there is an ongoing crackdown on food safety, with even five-star establishments under fire, the enforcement only intensifies ahead of the festive season, when concerns around food adulteration increase. FSSAI has already taken action against food businesses across several states, including prohibition orders against Shree Shyam Foods, Bharat Food Products and KDP Food Industry in Rajasthan. Penalties were imposed on Dharwad Mishra Pedha and Food Processing Industry in Karnataka. Bikanervala and Param Dairy have received notices following consumer complaints. Param Dairy was asked to respond to allegations of fungal contamination, while Bikanervala was asked to provide details of its investigation, SOPs and corrective measures following a hygiene-related complaint. In Maharashtra, the FDA has stepped up enforcement across the milk and food supply chain, including suppliers, dairies, transporters, distributors, retailers and sweet makers, citing issues such as alleged unhygienic conditions, pest infestation, cold-chain lapses and adulteration. Authorities have also acted against the alleged sale of analogue or artificial cheese as dairy paneer in Shirdi.

SCORPIO LIFESTYLER SHOWCASED

New Mahindra BE 6 launched

AKBAR MERCHANT
Mumbai, August 15

MAHINDRA LAUNCHED THE BE 6 SPORTEQ, a new series within its electric SUV range, with prices starting at ₹11.45 lakh (ex-showroom) under a Battery as a Service (BaaS) model. Deliveries will begin on August 26, coinciding with Onam. The range comprises eight variants across 59 kWh, 70 kWh and 79 kWh battery options.

The entry-level 59 kWh ONE is priced at ₹11.45 lakh under BaaS, with the battery charged separately at ₹3.75 per km. Without BaaS, it costs ₹19.45 lakh. It gets a few other variants as well including a Formula E edition, Freedom edition as well as launch edition that tops out at ₹26.95 lakh.

Prices exclude the home charger and installation. Variants from TWO onwards feature a three-screen coast-to-coast display. Most variants get Mahindra's MAIA artificial intelligence (AI) architecture, which powers six software suites under the TEQ umbrella that also offers features like personalised tailgate messages. Mahindra said the new software features will be rolled out to existing BE 6, XEV 9e and XEV 9S owners through phased OTA updates from January 2027.

The update on the BE6 comes on the back of reducing sales with the SUV averaging only around 1,020 units a month in 2026 making it the brand's slowest selling born-electric SUV, with the others being XEV 9e averaging at around 1,800 units a month and the three-row XEV 9S at around 3,000 units a month making it the brand's highest selling electric SUV currently.

Mahindra also showcased the production-ready Global Pik Up, christened Scorpio Lifestyler in India.

Set to debut commercially by April 2027, it will be priced below ₹19.79 lakh.

Overseas, it will be sold as Mahindra Lifestyler across markets that include Australia, New Zealand, South Africa, Africa, West Asia and Latin America. The brand is exploring more right hand drive markets like Indonesia among others for exports of this model.

The BE 6 SPORTEQ is priced at ₹11.45 lakh under BaaS

Insolvency against Nyka Steel guarantor upheld by NCLAT

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
New Delhi, August 15

THE NATIONAL COMPANY Law Appellate Tribunal (NCLAT) has upheld an order passed by the NCLT, directing insolvency proceedings against a personal guarantor of Mumbai-based Nyka Steel.

A two-member bench of the appellate tribunal upheld a February 3, 2026 order of the National Company Law Tribunal (NCLT), Mumbai, which had admitted UCO Bank's plea to initiate insolvency proceedings against Asif Ahmed Siddique.

Section 95 of the Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code (IBC), 2016 allows creditors to start insolvency proceedings against debtors, which includes personal guarantors and partnership firms. Nyka Steel is already undergoing a Corporate Insolvency Resolution Process (CIRP) before the NCLT.

The petitioner had argued that no fresh deed of personal guarantee was executed for the April 12, 2018 sanction letter renewing and enhancing credit facilities to the corporate debtor, and that his guarantee covered only loans sanctioned in 2013 and 2017. He also contended that the contractual exposure under the Deeds of Guarantee was capped at ₹40 crore and the liability of the guarantor could not have been enlarged beyond the terms of the contract.

UCO BANK CASE

■ A two-member bench of the appellate tribunal upheld a February 3, 2026 order of the NCLT, Mumbai

■ Nyka Steel is already undergoing a Corporate Insolvency Resolution Process before the NCLT

Agastya Energy to invest ₹7,800 cr in AP

AGASTYA GREEN ENERGY, a part of Anubhav Agarwal Group, on Saturday announced its expansion into Integrated 12 GW Ingot and Wafer manufacturing at the Orvakal Industrial Area in Kurnool, Andhra Pradesh, with a project cost of approximately ₹7,800 crore. The expansion will complement the firm's existing solar cell. —PTI

Chennai startup's broadband chip moves into production phase

ANI
New Delhi, August 15

A DESIGN LINKED Incentive (DLI) Scheme-backed semiconductor startup has achieved first-pass silicon success with 'VIHAAN', an indigenous broadband networking System-on-Chip (SoC) built using the VEGA microprocessor, marking a key step towards taking the chip into production, the Ministry of Electronics and IT said on Saturday.

Chennai-based Aheesa Digital Innovations, a fabless semiconductor startup, taped out VIHAAN on Republic Day and achieved first-pass silicon success on Independence Day this year. The chip, designed for fibre broadband applications, will now proceed towards production tape-out, targeted for 2027, the ministry said.

The development comes as India's semiconductor design ecosystem expands, with the government saying companies supported under the DLI Scheme have cumulatively achieved more than 30 chip design tape-outs across various foundries and raised over $100 million in venture capital funding.

Aheesa had earlier this year raised about ₹40 crore from the Tamil Nadu Infrastructure Fund Management Corporation (TNIFMC) through the Tamil Nadu Emerging Sector Seed Fund (TNESSF) and other private investors. The funding is aimed at accelerating product development and supporting the firm's growth in the semiconductor space, according to the ministry.

Firms supported under DLI Scheme have cumulatively achieved over 30 chip design tape-outs across various foundries

The government said semiconductor chip design is a critical value driver across the semiconductor value chain, contributing up to 50% of overall value addition and accounting for around 15-35% of the bill of materials cost of electronic products.

The ministry said chip-design tools have also been made available to 455 organisations, including 350 academic institutions and 105 startups, through government semiconductor programmes.

Words Worth

SUNDAY, AUGUST 16, 2026

India's middle class is facing its worst crisis since 1991 due to AI disruption, stagnancy in incomes and wages, and soaring household debt

EXPRESS ARCHIVES

The MIDDLE-LIFE crisis

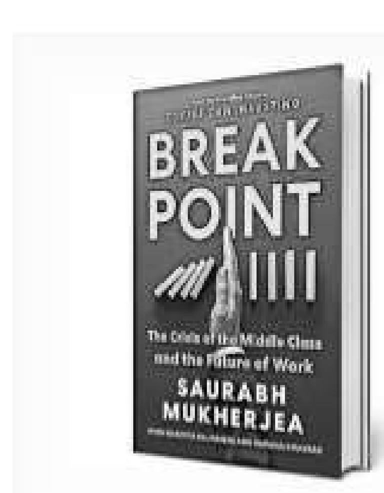
For a segment that drives India's economy, the middle class is severely stretched & strained

MADAN SABNAVIS

THE INDIAN ECONOMY has been a better performing one since the pandemic, with optimistic projections for the future as well. At the same time, we have also been hearing constant articulation by FMCG companies on consumption not quite picking up in the past few years. Consumption accounts for 60% of GDP. It is here that we may have to pause and reflect. In the book *Breakpoint* by Saurabh Mukherjea, written with Nandita Rajhansa and Sapna Bhavsar, this analysis is hard-hitting. The authors say the middle class will finally be the driver of the economy, and this is at a breakpoint. Mukherjea is spot on when he says the rich and poor are well taken care of by the government. The poor get all the subsidies and so-called freebies. The rich benefit from all the heavy expenditure incurred through capex outlays. But what about the middle class?

While 2025-26 did provide the right push in the form of tax cuts on both the direct and indirect taxes front, there can be a deeper-rooted problem. This is what the book explores, backed by very convincing data. This class accounts for most of the direct and indirect taxes that are paid to the government.

First, who is the middle class? The authors use a very practical number taken from the tax statistics which excludes agriculture. They pick up the bracket of ₹5 lakh-₹1 crore as the income cutoff, which is a fair enough approach. This gives a total of 40 million tax returns, which could roughly translate to 150-160 million people, which actually are required to do a lot of the spending to keep consumption ticking. His storyline is quite straight forward. First is the issue of employment. Here, rather than looking at overall unemployment



Breakpoint: The Crisis of the Middle Class and the Future of Work
Saurabh Mukherjea with Nandita Rajhansa & Sapana Bhavsar
Juggernaut
Pp 280, ₹799

rate, the authors use data to show that it is as high as 29% at the graduate level. This is significant because we are talking of qualified persons not finding jobs. The fault is not with the market but with the qualification or skill set. He highlights how the system of entrance exams could be flawed as students with engineering degrees do not have the capability of thinking or applying their minds as engineers. This is a reflection of the education system, which has to be tackled separately.

Second, the authors point out to stagnancy in incomes or wages over the years for this bracket of people. This story line fits in well with what one hears of in the corporate world where the increments given are limited, but the top layers get high remuneration in the form of bonuses and stock options. Intuitively one can see that if salaries do not increase, the spending power also gets curbed. Related to the above is the issue of real income which has been affected by inflation, which further puts pressure on households. There is a lot of data in the book to show this by comparing average salary per employee at two points of time based on wage bill and headcount.

In this kind of set-up he brings in the third factor of AI. Giving real examples based on the field work done by the authors, they show how AI has made human beings less important. It would be giving too much away by providing the examples here. There are several cases where not only is efficiency enhanced but costs saved by relying more on AI for better delivery of results.

While one can argue that AI may not be the best bet for a labour-surplus economy it is an inevitability that cannot be escaped. In fact, even if keep AI aside, there has been considerable labour displacing tools used by companies in the form of automation which has worked well. Therefore, a combination of the two has affected the hiring patterns over the years.

Now, Mukherjea adds a new dimension which is his domain — the stock market. This same class of people have put in a lot of money in the stock market in the F&O segment, ostensibly to earn better returns. But this can have nasty results as the quest to earn quick money leads to considerable losses. Mukherjea links this development with social media, where there is this new class of finfluencers who have shown the moon to followers thus leading to this explosion in F&O activity. In this context, he commends the government on what has been done on gaming, which has become another malaise, with people throwing in their hats, hoping to make quick money.

A phenomenon in parallel that has evolved at a prodigious pace is leverage at the household level. What was once used to purchase a house or an automobile has spread to consumption loans, which he believes may not be the best thing under conditions where incomes are not rising. Taking loans for holidays or experiences, or worse still, investing in the markets has increased the indebtedness of households that can have serious ramifications of default at some stage.

AI cannot replicate skills such as creativity, empathy and dexterity, which have a distinct human bias. There is need for reorientation of skill sets which will be in demand as AI takes over at a faster pace in the country. There is scope for creation of more entrepreneurial jobs which will be the new horizon that students will be aiming for. Quite clearly the nation is at a break point where there is need for the working class as well as the government from the point of view of policy to be more focused. This consumption impasse has to be passed and meaningful job creation is the way out, while taking into account the AI factor.

Breakpoint is another brilliant book from Mukherjea which is optimistic, but also serves as a wake-up call at several levels.

Madan Sabnavis is chief economist, Bank of Baroda

ON THE SHELF

THE POWER OF PULL
Rob Snyder
Hachette
Pp 288, ₹599

Rob Snyder followed all the traditional advice for launching a startup, but his company struggled to get off the ground. It wasn't until he left the standard playbooks behind that he was able to quickly scale to millions of dollars in revenue. In *The Power of Pull*, he strips business down to one counter-intuitive principle: Customer demand is all that matters. When business owners find real demand, they stop pushing their product onto an indifferent market, and instead customers pull the product out of their hands.

WHAT HAPPENED TO LIBERAL DEMOCRACY?
Daron Acemoglu
Hachette
Pp 416, ₹799

From its inception, liberalism offered a promise of shared prosperity, equality, democratic values and the free pursuit of knowledge. At first, it flourished. And then it faltered. One could say that liberalism is broken. So what comes next? Nobel prize-winning author Daron Acemoglu charts the rise and fall of liberal democracy, and offers hope for a way forward: a new theory that lays the groundwork for how we can — and must — remake liberalism before it's too late.

DESIGN LOVE IN
Marcus Buckingham
Penguin Random House
Pp 256, ₹1,399

In *Design Love In*, Marcus Buckingham challenges conventional thinking about leadership by arguing that love is far more than an emotion; it is a measurable driver of performance, engagement, customer loyalty, and long-term business growth. Drawing on decades of research and personal experiences, Buckingham introduces a practical framework for leaders to intentionally 'design love in' to every aspect of their organisations.

THE BIG BOOK OF KASHMIRI LITERATURE
Onaiza Drabu
Penguin Random House
Pp 448, ₹699

This anthology of literature is as much an introduction into the literary landscape of Kashmir as a journey through its history. From pre-modern verse to radio plays, folk chants to *ghazals*, flash fiction to excerpts from a novel, *The Big Book of Kashmiri Literature* is compilation of memory and an anthology of voices. The reader will encounter scholars, saints, experimental dramatists and unlettered poets starting from the 14th century to today.

LAL THANHAWLA
Sanjoy Hazarika
Westland Books
Pp 412, ₹799

Researcher, author and journalist Sanjoy Hazarika delivers the definitive account of Mizoram's political history over the past century. At the heart of it is Lal Thanhawla, Mizoram's longest-serving CM. Hazarika outlines Lal Thanhawla's sophisticated dance of diplomacy and networking with major political stakeholders highlighting his bold, often controversial decisions to unlock the resources needed for the young, developing region.

History's unseen sweep

How human fallacies destroyed civilisations, in a novel tracing modern Hungary

ASHUTOSH BHARDWAJ

EXACTLY TWO DECADES ago, a young Hungarian filmmaker named György Pálfi released *Taxidermia* (2006), a startling film that narrated the history of modern Hungary through three generations of men. Each protagonist lived a life that bordered on perversion.

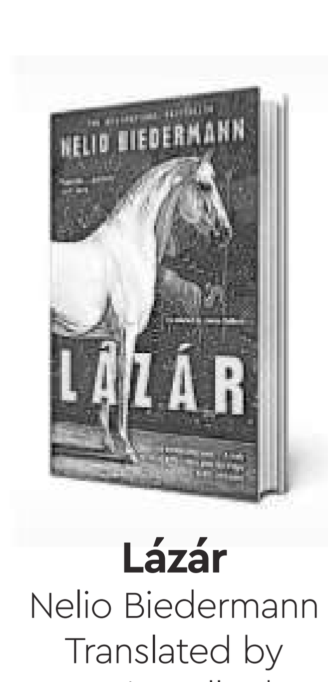
European literary circles are now abuzz with another attempt to narrate Hungary's turbulent century through three generations. This time the medium is not cinema but a sprawling family novel. Nelio Biedermann's *Lázár* begins in the fading years of the Habsburg monarchy and ends in the aftermath of the Soviet crushing of the Hungarian uprising in 1956. The novelist, just 22, is even younger than Pálfi was. The book has already been compared to the great European family sagas, including Thomas Mann's *Buddenbrooks*.

The novel opens at the turn of the 20th century in a mansion bordered by a forest. The estate's owner, Sandor Lázár, watches the birth of his son with horror because of the strikingly different skin of the baby. The setting promises a gothic drama wrapped in mystery.

But Biedermann spends nearly 70 pages tracing the intricate emotional and sexual entanglements of the family. Sandor conducts an affair with a lowly married factory worker. His wife, the baroness Maria, seeks intimacy elsewhere, first with a horseman and later with the tutor of her children. Their daughter Ilona develops an obsession with the same tutor and, upon discovering his attachment to her mother, fabricates a molestation accusation that leads to his murder. On top of it, while the world believes Sandor to be the father of Lajos, only Maria knows otherwise.

The Lázár family inhabits a privileged rhythm of life, an entrenched monarchy that appears permanent. That the reader alone knows what's lurking beyond the forest adds a layer of irony.

For nearly one-fourth of its length, the narrative crawls through a limited temporal frame. One can sense that the betrayals and lies are a signal to a larger decay, the final movements of a social order approaching extinction. But one can't



Lázár
Nelio Biedermann
Translated by Jamie Bulloch
Hachette
Pp 304, ₹699

A 1956 Hungarian uprising memorial in Budapest. *Lázár*'s story begins in the fading years of the Habsburg monarchy and ends in the aftermath of the Soviet crushing of the revolt of 1956

avoid sensing either that a tauter opening could have served the narrative better.

The novel gains momentum with the outbreak of the First World War and the disintegration of the Hapsburg empire. Private lives begin to intersect with public catastrophe, and a Hungarian landscape comes to reflect the turbulent decades Europe lived through in the first half of the twentieth century.

One of the telling episodes arrives at the end of the third chapter, when Lajos undergoes psychoanalysis with a doctor who once studied under Sigmund Freud in Vienna. The doctor flaunts his connection to Freud while admitting that he never really understood what Freud actually meant. The scene aptly captures a continent fascinated by modern ideas while remaining uncertain about their meaning or implications.

Biedermann's penetrative vision tells us how fantasies turn into humiliations. Ilona, who once found men in blood-soaked military uniforms irresistibly attractive, later finds herself being strip-searched by SS officers. The novel also pays homage to its predecessors. Maria's death reminds you of Virginia Woolf who had stepped inside a river with stones in her cardigan. And Pista reads Marcel Proust when insomnia keeps him awake—Biedermann even reproduces the opening paragraphs of Proust's famous novel.

The novel depicts both Nazi occupation and Soviet liberation without ideological simplification. In an unforgettable scene, Soviet troops arrive at the Lazar estate demanding a woman for the soldiers. The family silently offers up a maid. In a few devastating paragraphs, the novel exposes the persistence of class privilege even at moments when history appears to have levelled all distinctions.

The communist decades that follow are portrayed with equal sharpness. The family's property is nationalised. Ilona emigrates to America. Lajos places a copy of *The Communist Manifesto* near the door in the hope that visiting officials will leave him alone. Naturally, it does not save him. When he telephones his sister overseas, he becomes irritated by the astronomical cost of the international call and the wastefulness of spending money listening to her howl.

The patterns of desire established in the opening chapters continue through subsequent generations. It becomes more direct with passing years. Lajos embarks on an affair, partly to "validate his masculinity" after a distance from his wife following childbirth. Decades later, forced into agricultural labour after leaving the mansion behind, Lajos's children, Pista and Eva, spend freezing nights in a tiny barn. And then a night arrives when physical proximity with his sister awakens feelings in Pista. Clearly, the novel insists on exploring uncomfortable territory. Like *Taxidermia*, though in a much subtler register, *Lázár* examines desires that lie beyond accepted boundaries.

By the time the novel reaches the Hungarian uprising of 1956, the world of the Lázár mansion has vanished. The surviving members of the family drift toward Switzerland, carrying memories of a social order that no longer exists.

Lázár is not a perfect novel. Some sections are overextended, and some seem hurriedly summarised. The aspiration to crunch the decline of a civilisation across six decades in 300 pages arrives with a cost.

What still makes the novel impressive is its vision that epochal events enter human lives through private channels. Drawing partly on his own family history, Biedermann transforms the story of one Hungarian aristocratic clan into a reflection on the destruction of old Europe. The world that seemed eternal in its opening pages disappears by the end. The awareness about a civilisation that lost itself to its unbridled desires lends *Lázár* its power.

Beautifully translated by Jamie Bulloch in elegant and melancholic prose, *Lázár* may not justify the comparisons to Mann. But it justifies its own intent. It understands that history arrives through love affairs, jealousies, betrayals and misunderstandings. It knows that collapse of empires is experienced through bedrooms, dining tables and family secrets. And doomed are those who fail to hear history's knock at their door.

Ashutosh Bhardwaj is an independent writer and journalist

Spotlight

SUNDAY, AUGUST 16, 2026

INDIA'S CARE ECONOMY

Investing 2% of India's GDP in the care economy could create 11 mn jobs, most of them for rural women, as per a new white paper by Transform Rural India. Currently, women spend about 305 minutes a day on unpaid care work, compared to just 56 minutes by men

LONGEVITY comes of age

Changing consumer habits and conversations around ageing, and a rapidly expanding wellness market leading to growing interest in living longer & healthier lives

SREYA DEB

JUST FIGURE THIS out — nearly half of India's population take concrete steps towards healthy ageing, dwarfing the 12% global benchmark and ranking first among all countries surveyed in prioritising longevity, as per a report released by the Boston Consulting Group (BCG) late last year. About 71% use digital tools, wearable trackers and AI-supported health solutions to stay active longer, compared to the 55% global average.

In India, slowing ageing is no longer a niche concept — it is gradually becoming part of how people in the country have started to think about their health. The demographic trends highlight this emerging shift. India's senior population (aged 60 years and above), currently at 153 million, is expanding rapidly and is projected to reach 347 million by 2050, fuelling this urgent cultural focus on preventive health and lifestyle management.

This, in turn, is making longevity the new buzzword of the wellness industry and leading to a commercial momentum unfolding in an already booming market. As per a report by business consulting firm Grand View Research, the global longevity and wellness pharmaceutical market was valued at $63.4 billion in 2025 and is projected to reach $106.0 billion by 2033, growing at a CAGR of 6.7%. India is expected to outpace the global average, with its longevity and wellness pharmaceutical market forecast to grow from $2.15 billion in 2025 to $4.09 billion by 2033, at a CAGR of 8.5%.

Hype or need?

Recently, American venture capitalist and entrepreneur Bryan Johnson questioned his life choices after being diagnosed with an 'incurable' disease. The 48-year-old billionaire biohacker is the same person who had previously talked about looking to 'conquer death' and claimed to have the body of an 18-year-old. Some of his most viral stunts in pursuit of eternal life include taking regular blood plasma transfusions from his own teenage son, claiming it had properties to reverse ageing.

Johnson's diagnosis of autoimmune gastritis, a chronic condition where the immune system mistakenly attacks healthy cells in the stomach lining, may have left him questioning whether his pursuit for better health and a longer life was worth all the effort, but longevity, as an interest area, has already become a major global wellness and financial megatrend.

The idea is to extend healthspan — the number of years a person lives free from chronic disease — rather than just extending the total lifespan.

"The interest in longevity and healthy ageing is not very surprising globally, simply because the healthcare systems have reached saturation where most pathologies can be addressed by appropriate and timely medical interventions," says Deepak Saini, professor at the Indian Institute of Science (IISc), Bengaluru.

Saini is also the convenor of the Longevity India Initiative, a pioneering research programme of the IISc aimed at "extending human healthspan and promoting healthy ageing tailored to the unique genetic, lifestyle, and demographic needs of the Indian population".

"The mainstay of this industry as of today is to fix what's bothering you so that you can live without any discomfort. Technically that would require addressing the problem followed by maintaining wellness for as long as possible," he adds.

In India, the disease burden is changing — infectious diseases, while still significant, have given way to chronic conditions such as diabetes, cardiovascular disease, cancer, arthritis, dementia and osteoporosis as the leading causes of illness and death. According to the Sample Registration Survey of India for 2024, released this year, non-communicable diseases now account for more than 60% of the total deaths in the country. Many of these illnesses develop gradually over decades, making prevention and early intervention not only medically desirable but economically essential.

"The growing interest in living longer, healthier lives in India is an important trend, influenced by factors such as changing consumer habits, health statistics, and a rapidly expanding wellness market," says Dr Prasun Chatterjee, group clinical lead, geriatric medicine and longevity science, Apollo Hospitals.

Indian landscape

Across India's urban healthcare landscape, hospitals are expanding preventive health programmes that combine comprehensive laboratory testing, advanced imaging, cardiac risk assessment, genetic counselling where appropriate, and digital monitoring. Annual health check-ups, once considered executive perks, are increasingly marketed to middle-class families seeking to detect health risks before symptoms emerge.

Artificial intelligence is beginning to enhance radiology, pathology and predictive analytics, helping clinicians identify patterns that might otherwise be overlooked, while wearable devices continuously monitor heart rate, sleep quality, physical activity and even cardiac rhythm, generating streams of health data that were unimaginable a decade ago.

Last year, Deepinder Goyal, founder of Zomato and former CEO of Eternal, launched a $25-million personally-backed fund under his longevity venture Continue to invest in global research into human ageing and biological health. Continue operates on the principle that the human body has 'leverage points' or biological mechanisms that can influence ageing. Goyal was also an investor in Ultrahuman, a Bengaluru-based healthtech startup that tracked vital signs of the body.

Goyal has described the venture as beginning with investigating a simple hypothesis that, if validated, could fundamentally change our understanding of biology and ageing.

FROM BEAUTY TO SUPPLEMENTS AND HEALTH SCREENING, SEVERAL BRANDS ARE NOW TRYING TO TAP INTO THE LONGEVITY MARKET

Goyal has repeatedly stressed that the work is entirely self-funded and driven by scientific curiosity rather than commercial objectives. He supports researchers worldwide pursuing "unconventional, first-principles questions in biology, particularly those challenging established assumptions about human ageing".

When announcing his fund, Goyal had said on X, "For over a decade, I have believed that most of the world's problems stem from our short human lifespans. Continue Research's goal is to extend healthy human function long enough that humans stop making short-term decisions." He said it would be a "multi-decadal journey" that would "lead us into the post-Darwin era".

Growth engine

For brands, longevity is now becoming a way to unlock new growth. From beauty to supplements and health screening, several companies are trying to tap into this market by shifting from short-term wellness to long-term healthspan.

Companies such as Outlive India offer personalised longevity programmes focused on nutrition, metabolic health, fasting-mimicking protocols, fitness and lifestyle optimisation, while Decode Age provides biological age testing, epigenetic and gut microbiome analysis, longevity supplements and educational resources designed to help individuals better understand the ageing process. Other emerging players include Loop Health and Truemeds, which emphasise preventive health and chronic disease management through technology-enabled care, alongside diagnostic providers such as Redcliffe Labs, Apollo Longevity Clinic, and Metropolis Healthcare that are expanding access to advanced health screening and biomarkers relevant to healthy ageing.

"Longevity in India cannot become another category built purely around supplements, expensive diagnostics or cutting-edge interventions. It has to be data and outcome-driven, and ultimately accessible enough to become part of how people live every day," says Outlive India founder Varun Khanna. The company provides plans and packages for one-day and five-day fasting longevity programmes, supported by a team of scientists, nutritionists, and doctors. "Our customers have full transparency of the people and companies involved at every stage, from production to packaging," he adds.

Khanna also believes that the commercial opportunity in longevity is not necessarily about creating entirely new behaviours. "In many cases, it is about formalising enormous existing behaviours, making them easier to follow and giving consumers a way to understand whether they are actually working."

A large part of the longevity conversation gets muffled and misdirected on account of the unscientific discourses on social media. As per the company's mission, as outlined on the website, longevity is about conscious ageing, and unlocking the full potential of the body. "I believe the Indian longevity opportunity may ultimately take us closer to home, towards nutrition, fasting, movement and other practices that have existed in some form for generations, now validated, structured and made measurable through modern science," says Khanna.

Meanwhile, as per a 2026 study by market research company SNS Insider, of all the types of technologies, genomics and epigenetics are estimated to capture a share of 24.25% of the global market revenue due to their significance in the field of personalised medicine and biological ageing studies. Biomarkers and ageing clock technologies (AI computed algorithms to estimate biological ageing versus chronological ageing) are estimated to be the ones that will register the fastest growth until 2035, with a CAGR of 12.49%. This is due to increasing demand for assessing one's biological age and health monitoring.

FUNCTIONAL ABILITY, NOT PURSUIT OF YOUTHFULNESS, SHOULD REMAIN THE CORE OF AGEING POLICY & HEALTHCARE, AS PER WHO

"Although the field of personalised genomics is quite new and has not yet come into full practice, it has great potential in this area in the future," says Dr Sushila Kataria, vice chairperson, internal medicine, Medanta Gurugram. "People with a high family incidence of diseases, especially cancer, ask about the probability of them contracting it and whether they should consider taking genetic counselling or undergoing whole genome testing in order to reduce their risks."

On the research front, Longevity India, a multidisciplinary initiative led by the IISc with academic and clinical partners, is advancing scientific understanding of ageing and promoting collaboration across medicine, biology and public health. "One of the first initiatives of the study is to define the Indian baseline health features which can be used to develop predictive algorithms for preventive healthcare," says Saini, convenor of the initiative.

He further explains, "There are three features which affect one's health — what we eat, what we breathe, and what we come in contact with. And all the three parameters in India are different from what the Western population faces."

According to Saini, the long-term vision would be to shift healthcare practices from tertiary care or large hospitals to primary healthcare facilities. "Very simple diagnostic tests can reveal early onset of pathologies or early intervention which will fall into preventive healthcare regime."

Diagnostics represent another critical pillar of the longevity economy. Screening for diabetes, cardiovascular disease, kidney function, liver health, vitamin deficiencies, bone density and certain cancers has become increasingly common among middle-aged adults. While excessive or unnecessary testing remains a concern among clinicians, appropriately targeted preventive screening has become an accepted component of evidence-based healthcare for individuals with relevant risk factors.

Around the world, specialised clinics now offer biological age assessments, advanced biomarker testing, microbiome analyses, continuous glucose monitoring, hormone evaluations and personalised health optimisation programmes.

Saini says that longevity treatments can be understood as three phases — the first point is to identify the issue which is preventing us from leading a fulfilling life, the second is to retain wellness status as long as possible, and the third is to prevent future illnesses," he says. "However, the fundamental problem for India is the lack of basic health data and parameters which are relevant for disease prediction and preventive health regime deployment."

Technology is becoming another defining characteristic of India's longevity ecosystem. Wearable devices that monitor heart rate, physical activity, sleep quality and blood oxygen levels are no longer niche products but mainstream consumer electronics. Continuous glucose monitors, once reserved primarily for people with diabetes, are increasingly being used by health-conscious individuals seeking insights into metabolic health, although experts caution that evidence for routine use among healthy individuals remains limited. Artificial intelligence is also finding applications in preventive healthcare, from interpreting imaging scans and analysing retinal photographs to predicting disease risk using electronic health records.

A global summary by market research firm Spherical Insights showed that the wellness technology market accounted for approximately $57.1 billion in 2025 and is expected to surpass $208.36 billion by 2035, expanding at a CAGR of 13.82%. Notably, the global wellness tourism market reached nearly $990.4 billion in 2025 and is anticipated to hit $2.4 trillion by 2035, growing at a CAGR of 9.3%.

Filling the gaps

The World Health Organization has consistently emphasised that functional ability, rather than the pursuit of youthfulness, should remain the central objective of ageing policy and healthcare.

The recently established network of Ayushman Arogya Mandirs, grassroots public health facilities in India created by upgrading existing sub-health centres and primary health centres, places renewed emphasis on comprehensive primary healthcare, including screening for non-communicable diseases that contribute significantly to disability in later life.

The private sector is also moving to fill emerging gaps. Corporates increasingly incorporate preventive screenings, mental health support, nutrition counselling and fitness coaching in their wellness programmes as employers recognise the long-term benefits of maintaining a healthier workforce.

Many advanced longevity services remain concentrated in metropolitan areas and accessible primarily to higher-income consumers, raising important questions about equity and access in a country where healthcare expenditure continues to be highly out-of-pocket for many households.

India is part of a much larger global shift. Countries such as Japan, Singapore, Switzerland and the United States have invested heavily in healthy ageing research, precision medicine, age-friendly cities and technologies that support independent living. Japan, where nearly one in three people is aged 65 years or older, has pioneered community-based integrated care systems designed to help older adults remain active within their own neighbourhoods. Singapore has developed national strategies focused on preventive health, active ageing and lifelong employability, while the United States and Europe have seen the emergence of longevity-focused biotechnology, regenerative medicine and specialised clinics.

Going forward, the longevity industry, if guided by scientific evidence rather than marketing hype, has the potential to become more than a commercial opportunity, say experts. "While people in India are living longer, many aren't enjoying good health during those extra years. This has led to a change in focus from just living longer to living better, ensuring more years are spent in good health rather than in sickness," adds Dr Chatterjee of Apollo Hospitals.

FOR A LONG LIFE

$63.4 bn
Size of the global longevity & wellness pharmaceutical market in 2025

$106 bn
Projected size of the global longevity & wellness pharmaceutical market by 2033

$2.15 bn
Size of the Indian longevity & wellness pharmaceutical market in 2025

$4.09 bn
Projected size of the Indian longevity & wellness pharmaceutical market by 2033

153 mn
India's current senior population (aged 60 years and above)

347 mn
Projected population of India's seniors (aged 60 years and above) by 2050

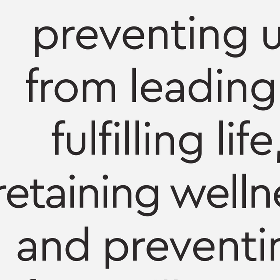
50%
of India's population actively think about healthy ageing, compared to 12% globally

71%
of Indians use tech such as fitness trackers & health apps to help them stay active, healthy

25%
of Indians use AI-powered health tools, the highest in the world

There are three phases to longevity treatments — identifying the issue that's preventing us from leading a fulfilling life, retaining wellness, and preventing future illnesses

— DEEPAK SAINI, LONGEVITY INDIA, IISC BANGALORE



The Indian longevity opportunity may ultimately take us towards nutrition, fasting, movement and other practices that have existed in some form for generations

— VARUN KHANNA, FOUNDER, OUTLIVE INDIA

Leisure

SUNDAY, AUGUST 16, 2026

RARE GOLDEN EGG

A 22-carat golden egg from a 1980s' ad campaign has sold for a record £123,500 at an auction in Lincolnshire, England. The Cadbury's Conundrum egg, which was a prize in a nationwide treasure hunt by the chocolate maker in 1983, sold at six times its estimated value

Quick bites get FIBREMAXXED

How snacks are embracing the next wave of functional nutrition

VAISHALI DAR

WHAT BEGAN AS a struggle with late-night snacking in the hostel quickly turned into a turning point for Mansi Kalyan. Realising how her food choices were affecting her health, the 23-year-old engineering student started to focus on fibre-rich options to maintain stable energy levels, support digestion, and prevent the sluggishness associated with sugary or fried snacks. She swapped processed, low-nutrient snacks for fibre-rich alternatives like beans, lentils and chia-based items. Gradually, her relationship with food improved.

Kalyan's story reflects a broader shift among young consumers who are increasingly prioritising fibre in their diets. Across India, this growing awareness is reshaping food choices — signalling a clear and decisive transformation in the country's snacking culture. From millet chips and roasted *makhanas* to quinoa *khakhras* and seed mixes, brands are reformulating products around fibre-rich ingredients to meet the growing demand for digestive health, satiety and long-term wellness. This shift is also being amplified online.

Industry bodies see structural tailwinds supporting fibre growth. "The global shift toward healthier snacking is creating strong momentum for fibre-rich foods," says Gunjan Vijay Jain, president of the Nuts and Dry Fruits Council (India). "Nuts and dry fruits offer a clean, plant-based source of fibre along with essential vitamins, minerals and healthy fats," adds Jain.

According to Mintel's Global Food and Drink Predictions 2026, fibre and protein are among the most easily understood nutrients, making them powerful drivers of choice. "At a time when there's an abundance of instantly available health advice, protein and fibre are cutting through the clutter in 2026 and going mainstream as accessible and essential nutrients," says Michelle Teodoro, associate director of food science for Asia-Pacific at Mintel.

Fuelling the demand

The 2025 ITC Aashirvaad Happy Tummy survey found that nearly 70% of Indians fall short of their recommended daily fibre intake, with women particularly affected. This gap is becoming a key driver of innovation for FMCG companies to expand fibre-rich offerings across categories. "Fibremaxxing is a growing trend among consumers today, where they are consciously taking steps to increase the fibre quotient in their diet," says Hemant Malik, executive director at ITC. "Consumers have started to understand the gut-brain connection and its role in mental, physical and overall well-being."

The company has been expanding its 'better-for-you' portfolio as part of its 'Help India Eat Better' strategy. "Sunfeast Farmlite offers fibre-rich cookies, Yoga Bar has oats, muesli and breakfast bars packed with fibre, while our Right Shift range is designed for consumers above 40 with high-fibre cookies and millet mixes that support gut health," adds Malik.

During the October 2025 earnings call, PepsiCo CEO Ramon Laguarta announced that fibre will be the company's next major nutritional focus, termed 'the next protein,' to align with consumer health trends and GLP-1 medication usage. Globally, the company is aggressively updating its portfolio to remove artificial ingredients and boost fibre/ protein content.

PepsiCo India is also aligning innovation with this evolving consumer preferences." As lifestyles become increasingly busy, consumers are looking for smarter snacking options that combine taste, convenience and functional benefits. We are seeing growing interest in fibre-rich choices, particularly among urban consumers and younger audiences," says Saakshi Verma Menon, chief marketing officer — foods, PepsiCo India.

NEARLY 70% OF INDIANS FALL **SHORT OF THEIR RECOMMENDED** DAILY FIBRE INTAKE, AS PER REPORTS

While the brand's Quaker portfolio, which includes oats-based products naturally rich in fibre, caters well to this demand, Menon adds that the brand is also exploring ways to bring traditional grains into modern formats. "For instance, Kurkure Jowar Puffs is inspired by jowar... reflecting how we are evolving the portfolio to match changing consumer preferences," says Menon.

With added convenience

Among a variety of emerging brands that are building fibre into their core proposition, the nutrient is not just a claim, but foundational to product design. "Fibre-rich snacks are gaining momentum globally as the 'fibermaxxing' trend grows," says Pune-based Pranav Korke, co-founder and CEO of The Healthy Binge, a brand that has built its snack portfolio around indigenous grains such as ragi, jowar, chickpeas and amaranth-ingredients that naturally contain high levels of fibre.

"When we started the brand in 2021, our idea was simple: to go back to ingredients Indians have trusted for generations," Korke explains. "Grains like ragi, jowar, amaranth and chickpeas are high in fibre, so when we build snacks around them, fibre becomes an organic nutritional advantage rather than something we artificially add later."

While fibre's appeal extends beyond health, it also aligns with modern consumption patterns. "People are looking for snacks that are easy to carry, quick to eat and still nutritionally balanced," he adds.

This intersection of convenience, satiety and nutrition is making fibre a strong contender in urban, on-the-go snacking. The trend is also reinforced by the rise of clean-label and plant-based eating.

Brands such as Healthy Master are capitalising on this shift with baked and roasted snacks made from millets, oats, nuts and seeds. Founded in 2019, the Bengaluru-based brand has built a portfolio of baked and roasted snacks made from millets, oats, nuts and seeds.

Tarun Agrawal, co-founder of the brand, says, "We primarily sell through direct-to-consumer channels and quick-commerce platforms including Blinkit, Zepto, Swiggy Instamart, Amazon Now, BigBasket and Flipkart Minutes. After expanding across India, we now process around 75,000 orders per month, with quick commerce already contributing 50% of its sales—a share expected to rise to 75% over the next year."

Similarly, Farmley is leveraging nuts, seeds and makhanas as fibre-rich formats. "Consumers are looking for snacks that deliver multiple benefits which include fibre, protein and healthy fats. Through formats like roasted makhanas, ready-to-eat trail mixes and seed ingredients, we make it easier for consumers to include fibre in their daily routines," says Akash Sharma, co-founder of Farmley. The brand's fibre intake — including nuts, seeds, roasted snacks and trail mixes — now account for around two-thirds of Farmley's snack portfolio.

Bringing the billboard to life

3D & digital out-of-home advertising helping brands to stand out, engage consumers & drive social media buzz

VAISHALI DAR

IF YOU'RE DRIVING on the Delhi-Noida Direct (DND) Flyway in the National Capital Region, chances are that you've already noticed a giant, working fan with rotating blades mounted onto a billboard. Set against a green, foliage-inspired backdrop, the creative integrates the product — Orient Electric Aero O2 fan — directly into the hoarding, turning it into a functional demonstration from a static display.

Similarly, home appliances brand Kelvinator's pan-India Summer Paused campaign uses three-dimensional billboards featuring ice-themed elements and frozen textures to showcase its heavy-duty WiFi inverter air conditioners. Meanwhile, real estate developer Godrej Properties created a striking 3D illusion with an architectural façade emerging from a standard billboard, blurring the boundary between advertising and architecture.

Welcome to the world of immersive, technology-led outdoor advertising in which brands are investing in three-dimensional and digital out-of-home (DOOH) experiences to stand out in crowded urban spaces.

Industry veterans say the shift reflects a broader change in marketing strategy — from simply buying visibility to creating memorable brand experiences. "As media environments become cluttered, brands need to shift from visibility to experience," says Shantiswarup Panda, head of marketing & visual merchandising at Indriya, Aditya Birla Jewellery. The jewellery brand has incorporated both physical 3D hoardings and anamorphic installations into its premium branding strategy.

"Our 3D hoardings in markets like Indore, where bangles and earrings literally step out of the frame, go beyond attracting attention. They build memorability and spark organic conversations," says Panda.

Atul Shrivastava, director & CEO of advertising company Laqshya Media Group, says the demand for innovative billboard executions has risen steadily across sectors ranging from FMCG to aviation. "The innovation lies in the creative execution, and the budgets vary as per the concept," he says. Laqshya has executed campaigns for brands such as Santoor, Chandrika, Tata Tea, Fortune, Air India and Jeep.

The investment required depends on the scale and complexity of the execution. A 3D-DOOH installation can cost anywhere between ₹2 lakh and ₹50 lakh a month, while premium digital billboards range from ₹5 lakh to ₹15 lakh a month depending on the city, screen size and location.

According to Balwant Mehra, founder and MD of Global Media Marketing and Communications, premium digital sites command rentals of up to ₹50 lakh a month, compared with ₹10-15 lakh for conventional hoardings in prime locations, underscoring advertisers' growing willingness to pay for more engaging outdoor media.

The next wave of growth is expected to come from beyond the metros. Rajesh Radhakrishnan, co-founder and chief marketing officer of Vritti iMedia, a division of Vritti Solutions, a pioneer in DOOH media, says brands are exploring 3D OOH in transit environments such as Metro stations, railway terminals, bus shelters and large cultural gatherings. The company has executed anamorphic campaigns for brands like Lux, Lifebuoy, Wheel, Rin, Dove and Clinic Plus.

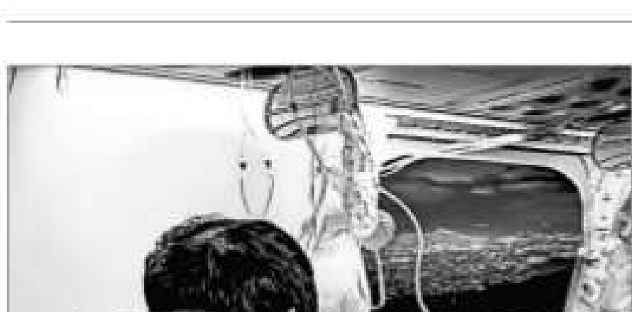
"From a marketing perspective, 3D OOH delivers value high recall, social amplification when people photograph and share 3D installations on social media, and helps brands communicate innovation," adds Radhakrishnan.

In terms of experiential marketing, more consumers have become desensitised to conventional advertising, says Chirag Divakaran, co-founder & creative director at advertising agency Orange and Teal. "In billboard-heavy markets such as Bengaluru, 3D installations help brands overcome visual fatigue, while in cities where experiential outdoor advertising is still evolving, they offer an opportunity to introduce something genuinely new," says Divakaran.

Orange and Teal has experimented with custom die-cut billboards instead of conventional rectangular hoardings, including one for the luxury residential project Amara in Chennai that drew inspiration from the project's architecture.

The shift reflects a broader change in marketing strategy — from simply buying visibility to creating memorable brand experiences

SCREEN TIME | *Your entertainment bucket list for this week*



FREEFALL: A RECKONING FOR BOEING

Netflix

Releases: **August 19**

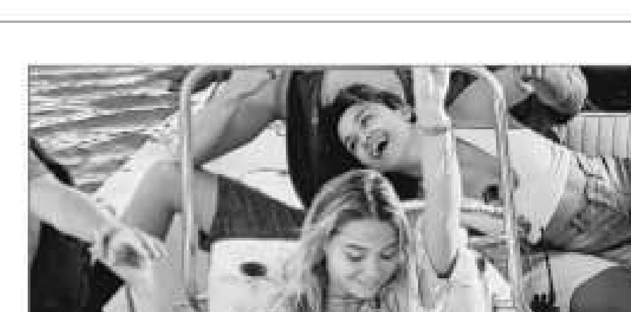
THE FILM REVISITS the aviation giant's history, picking up after Rory Kennedy's 2022 documentary, *Downfall: The Case Against Boeing*. Following the death of whistleblower John Barnett, the film examines Boeing's safety record, corporate culture and the allegations raised by employees. Kennedy brings together whistleblowers, insiders and other voices to investigate whether Boeing addressed the failures exposed by the fatal 737 MAX crashes.

NOVAK DJOKOVIC: THE WOLF IN WINTER

Prime Video

Releases: **August 20**

WITH 24 GRAND Slam titles — the most in men's history — over 1,100 career singles match wins, an Olympic gold medal, a record 428 weeks at world No. 1, and more Grand Slam appearances than any player in the Open Era, Djokovic has rewritten the record books. Through exclusive behind-the-scenes access at major tournaments, his intense training regiment, and softer moments at home, the film offers an unprecedented and revealing look at Djokovic's world.



OUTER BANKS SEASON 5

Netflix

Releases: **August 20**

OUTER BANKS RETURNS for its fifth and final season with the Pogues facing their biggest personal battle yet. After JJ's tragic death in Morocco, John B, Sarah, Kiara, Pope and Cleo are left grieving while the Blue Crown slips from their grasp. With Chandler Groff still at large, Dalia and the Corsairs closing in, and the Kooks threatening their home, the group must put aside their differences and fight back. An uneasy alliance with Rafe adds another layer of tension as the Pogues embark on a desperate quest for revenge, freedom and a future together, one final time.

INSIDIOUS: OUT OF THE FURTHER

Theatres

Releases: **August 21**

INSIDIOUS: OUT OF the Further follows Gemma, a mother raising her daughter in the house where she grew up. Her life takes a terrifying turn when she discovers she can travel into The Further, the realm inhabited by lost souls. But Gemma's ability comes with a dangerous twist: she can bring entities from The Further into the real world. As an evil presence targets her, demons begin exploiting her power, turning her home into a hunting ground.

PAW PATROL: THE DINO MOVIE

Theatres

Releases: **August 21**

AFTER A STORM sends their ship crashing onto an uncharted island, Ryder and his team of heroic pups discover a world inhabited by dinosaurs and meet Rex, a stranded pup with expert knowledge of prehistoric creatures. Trouble begins when their nemesis, Mayor Humdinger, starts mining the island for natural resources, triggering the eruption of a dormant volcano.

— COMPILED BY MITALI

Living

SUNDAY, AUGUST 16, 2026

How to assemble the perfect SLEEP KIT

From tech support to wellness products, an entire industry has woken up to give you a good night's rest

VAISHALI DAR

YOUR BEDSIDE TABLE is getting a wellness makeover. The glass of water and phone charger now share space with lavender pillow mists, calming herbal teas, eye masks, magnesium supplements and smart sleep trackers. Welcome to the new-age sleep kit, which goes well beyond a good mattress and pillow.

Breathable bedding that keeps you cool through the night, aromatherapy to ease stress, herbal remedies that encourage relaxation, sound machines that drown out distractions and wearable technology that analyses every hour of slumber. Together, these products are turning bedrooms into personalised sleep sanctuaries.

Tech in bedroom

Sleep is no longer as simple as switching off the lights and nodding off. Smart sleep systems combine comfort with data-driven insights to create personalised rest experiences. Globally, products such as the Eight Sleep pod regulate mattress temperatures, monitor sleep stages and adjust sleeping conditions automatically through connected applications. Advanced systems can detect disruptions throughout the night and provide personalised recommendations to improve sleep quality over time.

Orthopaedic and heating solutions brand, Heatronics has introduced heated beds and foot warmers that use gentle warmth to promote relaxation, particularly among older adults, people with chronic discomfort and those living in colder climates. Mattress are getting AI makeovers, and companies are positioning themselves as sleep wellness brands. Home and sleep solutions brand Wakefit's Zense, an AI-powered sleep solutions suite, features products like Regul8 and Track8. Zense has developed smart sleep products including Regul8, an automated temperature controller that helps maintain an optimal sleep environment, and Track8, a contactless sleep tracker that provides users with personalised insights into their sleep patterns.

The company has a sleep internship that pays people to sleep for nine hours every night. "This sits at the heart of what we're trying to do: help India sleep better," says Chaitanya Ramalingegowda, director and co-founder.

Choosing the right pillow is equally important, and depends on your sleeping position. Pillows memory foam, microfibre, and hollow fibre options are the most popular choices to keep the head and neck aligned.

Shut eye business

From beauty and wellness brands to the hospitality industry, sleep rituals are not taken lightly. A ghee collagen sleeping mask with Gotu Kola exosomes, peptides from beauty brand Ohria Ayurveda can turn bedtime into an extension of skincare, while Forest Essentials and Coral & Sky offer pillow mists, eye masks, essential oils and aromatherapy sprays for a calming bedtime. Hospitality brand Hilton's 2026 Trends Report states 'hushpitality' as a rising travel trend on intentional silence, low-stimulation environments, and sensory rest rather than jam-packed sightseeing, with 56% of leisure travellers citing 'rest and recharge' as the primary purpose of their trips. Dedicated sleep programmes go far beyond premium mattresses in the industry. Six Senses Vana in Dehradun offers personalised consultations that assess sleep patterns, stress levels and lifestyle habits before creating tailored wellness plans. Tulah Clinical Wellness Centre in Kerala provides specialised sleep programmes for guests seeking structured interventions, while The Wellness Retreat at Karma Lakelands in Gurugram has special sleep and restoration protocols. Internationally, wellness hospitality is becoming more specialised. The Longevity Suite Retreats at Mett Singapore, scheduled to launch in September, will feature guestrooms aligned with guests' circadian rhythms.

On the other hand, Indian Railways has introduced sleeping pods at Visakhapatnam railway station as a pilot project, offering affordable, capsule-style accommodation for short stays and overnight rest. Equipped with Wi-Fi, modern bathrooms, luggage storage and dedicated facilities for women, the pods reflect travellers' growing willingness to pay for privacy, comfort and quality sleep, even in transit.

Pop a nap

The rise of the sleep economy has boosted demand for sleep supplements too, particularly melatonin. These are available as gummies, tablets and more, and are available over the counter. However, doctors caution against indiscriminate use, stressing that supplements should support and not replace healthy sleep habits. Long-term sleep health depends on consistent routines, limiting screen time before bed, managing stress and creating a restful environment, say medical experts.

PALATE TEASER

Tahini with a twist

The middle-eastern condiment is surprisingly adaptive to Indian food

SUGANDHA MUKHERJEE

FOR YEARS, TAHINI IN INDIA tended to arrive in the same tray which had hummus, baba ganoush, a plate of warm pita. The creamy paste of ground sesame seeds was shorthand for middle eastern mezze platter. Now it is turning up in less predictable places. Chefs are spooning it over *tandoori* potatoes, folding it into *chaat,* whisking it into salad dressings and using it with *kebabs,* with its nutty, rich and faintly bitter flavour proving surprisingly accommodating to Indian food.

● The effect of fusion

In Delhi, Mumbai, Bengaluru and other large cities, tahini is a familiar ingredient on the menus of upscale restaurants and luxury hotels. At Ziya, at The Oberoi in Mumbai, *tandoori aloo* with tahini places the sesame paste alongside an Indian preparation. Pomegranate tabbouleh brings another middle eastern note to the menu. In Ahmedabad, Atrangi–The Modern Indian Kitchen offers an *atrangi* hummus *ki chaat,* in which silky chickpea-and-sesame hummus is dressed in the vocabulary of Indian street food. At Tahini-Middle Eastern Kitchen in Gurugram, the ingredient appears with adana *kebabs* and grilled platters. Tahini can become a dressing for grain bowls, roasted vegetables and salads, or a creamy binder in wraps. Bartenders are experimenting with tahini orgeat, using the paste in cocktails for body or fat-washing spirits to extract its sesame flavour without leaving its texture behind.

● The health appeal

Part of tahini's appeal is practical. Sesame paste contains unsaturated fats, fibre, plant-based protein and minerals including iron, copper and phosphorus. It is calorie-dense — 90 calories in a tablespoon — so a little goes a long way.

● From region to reinvention

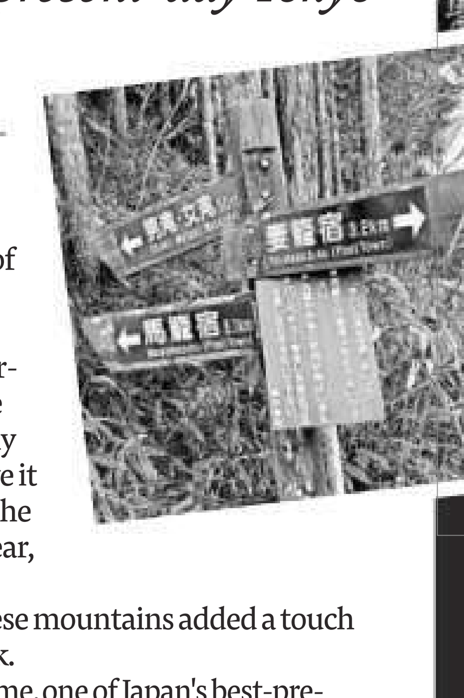
The word tahini comes from the Arabic *tahana,* meaning 'to grind', and the paste has deep roots in the middle east. In India, sesame is hardly exotic. White sesame has been part of Indian cooking and appears in winter foods around Makar Sankranti, in preparations such as Maharashtra's *bhogichi bhaji,* and in chutneys served with rice, ghee in parts of southern India.

FOOTLOOSE

A walk between Japan's postal towns

Old meets the new on the Edo-period highway connecting Kyoto and the present-day Tokyo

SUGANDHA MUKHERJEE



THE FIRSTTHING I NOTICED after leaving the stone-paved streets of Magome was the bell. Hanging from a wooden post at the edge of the forest, it came with a simple instruction, "ring it loudly to keep bears away". I gave it a hearty clang, more for the experience than out of fear, though knowing Asiatic black bears still roam these mountains added a touch of excitement to the walk.

I had arrived in Magome, one of Japan's best-preserved *shukuba-machi,* or post towns, after a journey that reflected old meeting new. The journey began with a Shinkansen from Tokyo to Nagoya, a semi-rapid train to Nakatsugawa and finally a local bus climbing into the Kiso Valley. I stayed in a traditional *ryokan,* where dinner featured mountain vegetables, river fish and an astonishing variety of mushrooms — food that has long sustained travellers on this route.

Magome and neighbouring Tsumago once served as vital rest stops on the nearly 500-km Nakasendo, the Edo-period highway connecting Kyoto and Edo (present-day Tokyo). Merchants, pilgrims, samurai and feudal lords would spend the night here before continuing their journeys through the mountains. Today, the 8-km trail linking the two towns lets visitors experience that history on foot. The twin Otaki and Metaki waterfalls provided a memorable stop before the trail descended into Tsumago. Unlike many heritage villages that exist solely for tourists, Tsumago still feels lived in.

Wooden inns, lattice-fronted homes and carefully concealed power lines preserve the atmosphere of a functioning Edo-era town. While many hikers end their journey there, I walked another 3.5 km to Nagiso Station before catching a train towards Kyoto, leaving with the feeling that Japan's old postal towns are best understood by walking the roads that once connected them.

TRAVEL PLANNER

BEST TIME TO VISIT: APRIL TO NOVEMBER

- **WHAT TO WEAR:** Hiking clothes, comfortable shoes and a hat
- **WHAT TO EAT:** Grilled local fish, hot pot items, oyaki and pickles
- **HOW TO REACH:** Train from Nagoya Station to JR Nakatsugawa Station followed by a 30-minute local bus

CULTURAL CALENDAR

● Soulful melodies by Papon

August 16, Yashobhoomi, Delhi, 7 pm

Papon is performing live in the city, bringing a blend of folk, Bollywood hits, and soulful melodies to the stage. Known for his versatility and iconic tracks like *Moh Moh Ke Dhaage* and *Jiyein Kyun,* be there for a performance that has something for every mood.

● Explore Gandhi's life

on till August 19, Saffronart, Mumbai, 11 am–7pm

What if we could glimpse Gandhi beyond the Mahatma? Auction house Saffronart's archive of 86 artefacts offers just that — a personal portrait shaped by friendship, grief, faith and everyday correspondence. Preserved by the Hingorani family for generations, the collection brings closer to Gandhi as mentor, confidant and friend, beyond his public legacy.

● Stories from the north east

August 18, India Habitat Centre, Delhi, 7 pm

Journey into the north east through a compelling series of short films exploring its forests, wildlife, indigenous traditions and conservation struggles. Get a glimpse of Sikkim's Lepcha seed keepers and Nagaland's disappearing honey-hunting traditions.

● Musical night

August 16, DND Bellandur, Bengaluru, 8 pm

An unforgettable night with Indian Ocean, the legendary band famous for their fusion of rock, folk, and classical music. A musical evening where melodies and narratives come together on one stage with their classics like *Kandisa Bandeh* and *Ma Rewa*.

● The art of Kathak

August 21, Bangalore International Centre, Bengaluru, 7–8.30 pm

Experience Kathak in its most expressive form as dancer and choreographer Amruta Paranjape takes audiences through rhythm, movement and storytelling. Blending intricate *laya-taal*, *abhinaya* and spontaneous musical dialogue, the performance explores the playful Ninda Stuti between Shiva and Parvati.

—COMPILED BY MADHUSHREE GOSWAMI

Fe Lines

SUNDAY, AUGUST 16, 2026

STORIES AND TRENDS FROM INDIA AND AROUND THE WORLD THAT CAUGHT OUR FANCY

Slovak village of Vlkolínec (above) & Maasai communities (below) in Tanzania's Ngorongoro Conservation Area want to drop the UNESCO status UNESCO

Heritage STATUS QUO

Why some communities want their Unesco World Heritage Status back

VAISHALI DAR

BEING NAMED A Unesco World Heritage Site is usually the ultimate badge of global recognition. It promises prestige, international attention, conservation funding and a place on the bucket lists of travellers worldwide. But for some communities, the coveted designation is becoming a burden rather than a blessing.

Residents of the Slovak village of Vlkolínec and the indigenous Maasai communities in Tanzania's Ngorongoro Conservation Area are among those challenging the consequences of the esteemed status. Among their grievances include too many tourists, restrictions on how land and homes can be used, and growing concerns that the needs of residents are being sacrificed to preserve a landscape for visitors.

Vlkolínec, an intact settlement of traditional wooden houses in central Slovakia, was inscribed on the Unesco World Heritage List in 1993. Its typical architecture helped make it a global heritage site. But residents now argue that the village has been transformed from a living community into something resembling an open-air museum as over 100,000 yearly visitors crowd the tiny village of fewer than 20 permanent residents.

Tourism has brought crowds into a settlement where people still live. Residents have complained about visitors looking into homes and about the difficulty of carrying out renovations because of strict conservation requirements. What was once a traditional village, critics say, increasingly risks becoming a tourist attraction designed around preserving buildings rather than sustaining the people who live in them.

In Tanzania, the conflict is even more closely tied to indigenous rights. Maasai pastoralists and organisations including the Maasai International Solidarity Alliance have called for the Ngorongoro Conservation Area to be removed from the World Heritage List. They argue that conservation policies and tourism development have undermined their land rights and traditional livelihoods, and that the residents are displaced from ancestral grazing lands.

Meanwhile, Unesco has maintained that it has never called for the displacement of the Maasai, yet the communities including the Serengeti, Ngorongoro Crater, and Tarangire argue on traditional Maasai lands.

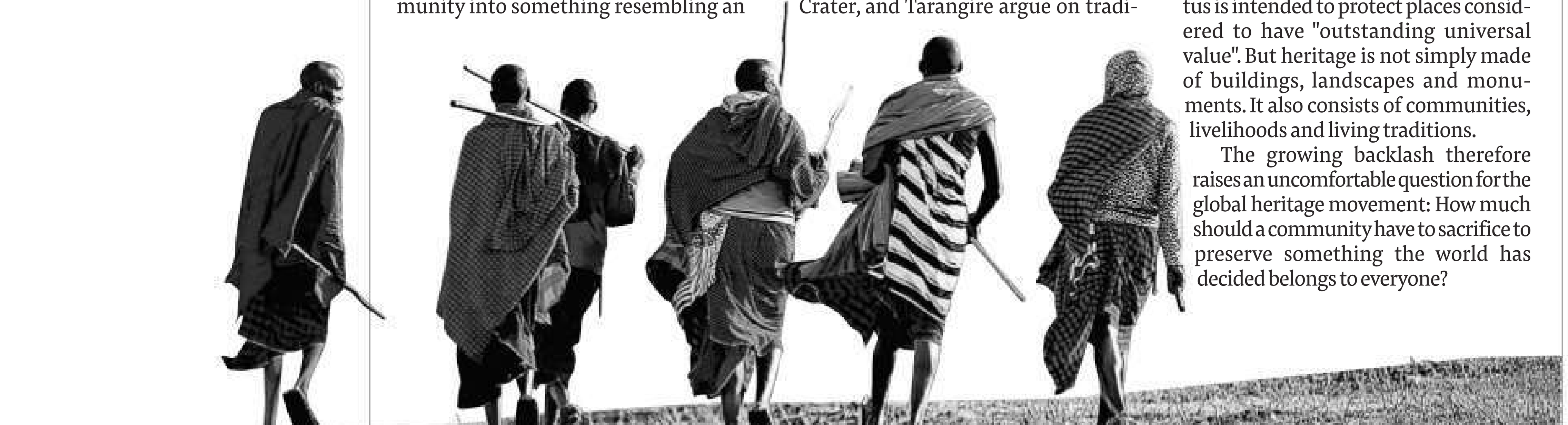
The English Lake District offers another version of the same debate. Awarded World Heritage Site status in 2017, the mountainous region and national park in Cumbria, Northwest England has since faced criticism from conservationists who argue that the designation can reinforce damaging patterns of tourism and land management. Campaigners have also questioned whether intensive sheep farming should continue to dominate the landscape, arguing that it can inhibit tree regeneration, biodiversity and rewilding.

But the irony is hard to miss: a status created to protect exceptional places can sometimes make it harder to change them. Unesco delisting is rare, but it is not unprecedented. Oman's Arabian Oryx Sanctuary became the first site to lose its World Heritage Site status in 2007 after the government reduced the protected area and proceeded with oil and gas exploration. Germany's Dresden Elbe Valley was delisted in 2009 after the construction of a bridge across the Elbe was deemed incompatible with the site's outstanding universal value.

Liverpool Maritime Mercantile City in England followed in 2021. Unesco removed it after large-scale redevelopment, including plans for a new football stadium and other construction, was judged to have damaged the historic character for which the site was recognised.

These cases show that delisting has traditionally been associated with development projects, government decisions or failures to protect heritage. The newer disputes in Vlkolínec, Ngorongoro and the English Lake District point to a more complicated question: what happens when the people living inside a World Heritage Site believe that protection itself has become intrusive? Unesco status is intended to protect places considered to have "outstanding universal value". But heritage is not simply made of buildings, landscapes and monuments. It also consists of communities, livelihoods and living traditions.

The growing backlash therefore raises an uncomfortable question for the global heritage movement: How much should a community have to sacrifice to preserve something the world has decided belongs to everyone?



TECH-NOW-LOGY

Recorder reimagined

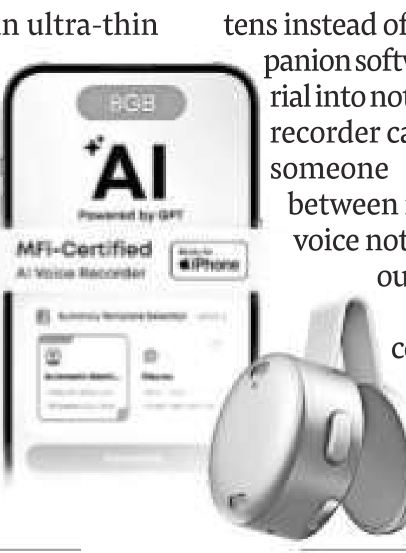
Devices today not only record but also transcribe conversations, identify speakers, summarise meetings and even organise info into structured notes — all with a touch of AI

SUGANDHA MUKHERJEE

THERE WAS A time when recording your voice meant putting an empty cassette into a rectangle metal box and pressing the record button. Later, the voice recorder app on a phone seemed revolutionary. You could record an impromptu singing session, save a college lecture for last-minute exam preparation or capture an interview without carrying another device. Now the recorder is learning to do more than record.

Hardware AI recorders are dedicated, pocket-sized devices designed to capture audio and connect it with artificial intelligence. They can transcribe conversations, identify speakers, summarise meetings, extract action points and, in some cases, organise information into mind maps or structured notes.

The category ranges from credit-card-sized devices to wearable recorders. The Plaud Note, for instance, is an ultra-thin recorder that offers two recording modes. Its microphones capture in-person conversations, while a vibration-conduction sensor can pick up phone calls when the device is attached to the back of a compatible smartphone using MagSafe. Its companion software can transcribe conversations in more than 110 languages and distinguish between speakers. Its sibling, the Plaud NotePin S, takes the recorder off the desk and puts it on the user. It can be worn as a pin or a necklace, allowing professionals to record hands-free. It offers up to 20 hours of recording. Other products are experimenting with different form factors. Soundcore Work, from Anker, is a coin-sized wearable recorder with a double-tap function that lets users mark an important point in a conversation. Hidock 1 is designed for the desk, recording online or face-to-face meetings through Bluetooth headphones.



FLASH STORAGE & RECHARGEABLE LITHIUM-POLYMER BATTERIES ALLOW THEM TO REMAIN SMALL ENOUGH FOR EVERYDAY USE

The hardware itself is straightforward but purpose-built. These devices typically use multiple MEMS (micro-electro-mechanical systems) microphones arranged in arrays to improve voice pickup, acoustic beamforming and noise isolation. Some models use vibration-conduction sensors to capture sound travelling through a phone's chassis. Flash storage and rechargeable lithium-polymer batteries allow them to remain small enough for everyday carrying.

The bigger attraction, however, is not the microphone. It is what AI does with the recording. For executives, an hour-long boardroom discussion can be converted into a summary, a list of decisions and follow-up tasks. Salespeople can use recordings to revisit client conversations. Lawyers and consultants can document meetings and consultations, subject to applicable consent and privacy requirements. For journalists, instead of repeatedly playing back an interview to find a quote, one can search a transcript and use speaker identification to locate relevant portions. Dedicated microphones and noise-cancellation systems can also help when interviews take place in crowded public spaces. Students and researchers are potential audience. A long lecture can be recorded while the student listens instead of typing continuously. Companion software can then turn the material into notes or summaries. A wearable recorder can capture a thought while someone is travelling, walking or between meetings. An unstructured voice note can later become a list, an outline or a reminder.

The convenience, however, comes with a price. Users frequently praise the transcription accuracy and the physical simplicity of devices such as the Plaud Note. Dedicated microphones can perform better than a phone in certain recording situations, while the one-touch operation removes the need to unlock a smartphone, open an app and start recording. But the biggest complaint is often what happens after the hardware has been purchased. Many AI recorders restrict the number of transcription minutes available on their free plans. A device that can cost more than $150 may come with only a limited monthly allowance, often around 300 minutes, after which regular users need to pay for a subscription. For someone recording meetings or lectures every day, those minutes can disappear quickly.

Hardware quirks can add another layer of frustration. Some models use proprietary charging accessories rather than the increasingly ubiquitous USB-C standard. Lose the cable while travelling and a functional recorder can become temporarily useless.

Disaster has a cute name

From female names for hurricanes like Katrina & Sandy, to typhoons named Dim-Sum or Dolphin, the logic behind naming natural calamities

SREYA DEB

A TYPHOON NAMED Haiyan, Dim-Sum, or Dolphin. A hurricane called Katrina. A winter storm referred to as Fern. Natural calamities are often given monikers that remain in public memory long after the floods and rains have died down, tectonic plates have stopped shifting, or the ashes have cooled. Incidentally, these deceptively unassuming names are in sharp contrast to the lives and livelihoods that these tragic natural calamities have laid waste to.

Why are they named so? Historically speaking, these names serve different purposes depending on the type of disaster — and, in some cases, there is no official naming system at all, with a mere public poll deciding what the natural disaster will be remembered as. Among the latest in the list of storms is the typhoon Dim-Sum, which was selected after Hong Kong invited the public to suggest culturally representative names and named after the familiar assortment of bite-sized dishes associated with Cantonese cuisine. Other suggestions included names such as Gaeguri (frog) from North Korea and Hebi (snake) from Japan.

The process varies from region to region. In the western North Pacific and South China Sea, names are contributed by members of the Economic and Social Commission for Asia and the Pacific (ESCAP) or the World Meteorological Organization (WMO) Typhoon Committee. The names can reflect local languages, nature, culture and everyday life. Another name that made headlines this year is Dolphin, which appears on the same regional list. The typhoon made landfall in China's Zhejiang province on August 9. This name was contributed by Hong Kong as a homage to the local Chinese white dolphins. Different from the Asian naming system of storms is the Atlantic one, which uses people's names and are allotted in an A-Z sequence. Some examples are

Typhoon Dolphin hit China's Zhejiang province in August AP/PTI

Haiyan (cyclone of 2013), Mangkhut (typhoon of 2018), Irma (hurricane of 2017), Maria (typhoon of 2024), Sandy (cyclone of 2024) and Katrina (hurricane of 2025). Notably, even though the Atlantic system reuses certain storm names, a number of them in the past, including Sandy and Katrina, had left such destruction in their wake that they were considered inappropriate to be used again.

When a deadly cyclone can make its name strongly associated with tragedy to reuse, regional committees can then retire it and select a replacement. Notably, until the late 1970s, hurricanes in the US were all named after women. The practice started when military meteorologists started naming Atlantic storms after their wives and partners in 1953, post weather discussions during World War II. The system changed as there was no scientific reason for storms to be considered 'female'. Starting in 1979, Atlantic hurricane lists included both men's and women's names, alternating between the two. According to the WMO, naming storms makes warnings easier to communicate, helps avoid confusion when several storms are active and improves public awareness and preparedness. There is no single worldwide list. Instead, WMO regional committees establish naming systems for different ocean basins.

Other natural calamities like earthquakes and volcanoes are named differently — rather than personal or perselected names, these are largely based on dates and locations. Earthquakes are named after their epicentre location and year in India. The US Geological Survey uses nearby populated places when assigning descriptive locations to earthquakes. Volcanic mountains and eruptions are named after the mountains, which can have historical value given that the mountains were named after people. Examples are the Mount St Helens eruptions of 1980, and the Mouth Hood and Mount Baker volcanoes, among others. Tsunamis are identified through the earthquake that generated them, rather than receiving a separate personal name. Wildfires are identified by a nearby geographical feature, road, community or other location. Ultimately, a disaster's name is less about giving nature a human identity and more about giving people a useful shorthand.

Well Being

SUNDAY, AUGUST 16, 2026

WORRYING FIGURES

The nationwide ICMR-INDIAB study found dyslipidaemia in roughly 81% of adults screened, with low HDL cholesterol in about two-thirds and elevated LDL in one in five

NEW CHOLESTEROL PILL A GAME-CHANGER?

What potential a new drug, earlier taken in the form of an injectable, holds, and how such a medication might alleviate the LDL burden in India

Advantages of a pill

- Improved convenience
- Long-term adherence
- More appropriate for patients with needle aversion
- Does not require refrigeration or special administration

Lifestyle for low cholesterol

- Regular physical activity
- Encouraging healthy eating
- Routine lipid panel after 18 years
- Tobacco cessation
- Weight management

SREYA DEB

FOR A LONG time, injectable PCSK9 inhibitors have remained a specialist's go-to drug to treat high low-density lipoprotein (LDL) levels, or the so-called bad cholesterol. The approval of a once-daily pill, Lipfendra, by the US Food and Drug Administration might change this discourse, experts say.

Whether it's cost, cold-chain storage, needle aversion or the need for repeated administration, "a pill removes most of that friction", says Dr Vishal Khullar, director, cardiovascular and thoracic surgery, heart and lung transplant, Fortis Hospital Mulund, Mumbai. "It moves this class from tertiary cardiology centres into the hands of the general physician and family doctor, which is where the majority of dyslipidaemia is actually managed," he adds.

Dyslipidaemia (or hyperlipidaemia) is a condition for which the burden is rising globally, including in India. So far, only an expensive injectable drug was available, but with the recent approval, the condition can now be managed with a prescribed pill, at least in the US. Doctors say this could make a marked difference in the treatment and management of this bad cholesterol burden, should the drug be approved for distribution in India as well.

Potential impact

The significance here is not that we have discovered a new way to lower cholesterol, say experts. "PCSK9 inhibition has been available for close to a decade, and we already know it works: evolocumab and alirocumab (sold as injectable medicines to block the protein and enzyme in order to lower LDL cholesterol) have proven cardiovascular benefit in large outcome trials," says Dr Khullar. "The significance is that this mechanism has finally been packaged into a tablet."

Dr Amit Kumar Malik, director, interventional cardiology and electrophysiology at Medanta Noida, explains further, "An oral option is likely to improve convenience, treatment acceptance, and long-term adherence, especially among patients who are reluctant to take injections."

Clinical studies have shown that it can reduce LDL cholesterol by nearly 60%, comparable to injectable PCSK9 inhibitors. If patients remain on therapy consistently, it has the potential to reduce the long-term burden of heart attacks and strokes.

"An oral medicine has several practical advantages. Unlike injections, it does not require refrigeration or specialised administration, making it easier to prescribe, distribute, and use in routine clinical practice. Whether it becomes truly affordable in India will depend on pricing and market competition. If these factors are favourable, wider adoption among eligible high-risk patients is certainly possible," Dr Malik adds.

Injectables have one underrated advantage, though, notes Dr Khullar. Someone administers them, so adherence is essentially guaranteed for that interval. "A six-monthly injection means the patient is protected for six months whether or not they remember. A daily pill goes onto a tablet pile that many of my patients already find overwhelming, and we know how poorly daily statin adherence holds up beyond the first year," he adds.

Hidden danger

Dr TS Kler, chairman of BLK-Max Heart and Vascular Institute, sheds light on the burden of LDL cholesterol: "As far as South Asia is concerned, including India, the problem is that LDL is high, while HDL (high-density lipoprotein), which is the protective cholesterol, is low. One of the most important factors causing heart disease is increased LDL, or bad cholesterol." He says that in situations where statins are not effective due to the severity of the condition "or are causing significant side effects, this medicine will be of great benefit".

"In India, many people do not know their cholesterol or LDL levels until they suffer a heart attack. Annual health check-ups should begin at a young age so that we know a person's lipid profile early and can take appropriate action," he adds.

According to Dr Khullar, the numbers in India are sobering. "A nationwide ICMR-INDIAB study found dyslipidaemia in roughly 81% of adults screened, with low HDL cholesterol in about two-thirds and elevated LDL in one in five."

"The burden is severe and, more importantly, it is largely invisible. High cholesterol shows no symptoms until it produces a catastrophe," he warns. "Cardiovascular disease is already the leading cause of death in India, and Indians develop it younger and with more aggressive disease patterns than most other populations."

Speaking from his own experience with patients, he says, "I see the end result of this on my operating table. I am regularly performing bypass surgery on men in their late 30s and 40s - patients whose fathers had their first heart attack at 50. Familial hypercholesterolaemia, which Lipfendra is specifically approved for, is estimated to affect around one in 250 people worldwide, which would put the Indian figure well over half a million - and the overwhelming majority of them have never been diagnosed," adds Dr Khullar.

Indian context

What kind of potential is this drug going to have in the Indian market? "The introduction of any new medicine in India depends on regulatory approvals, commercial decisions and clinical considerations. India has a strong pharmaceutical sector, and over time newer therapies often become available through different pathways, but it is too early to comment on any specific product or manufacturer," says Dr SK Wangnoo, senior consultant, endocrinology, Indraprastha Apollo Hospital, Delhi.

On how the pill is different from the injection, Dr Wangnoo says that expanding the range of treatment options supports a more personalised approach to cholesterol management. "The main difference is the route of administration, with one being an oral medication and the other an injectable therapy. Both are intended to help lower LDL cholesterol in appropriate patients. The choice of treatment should be based on clinical need, treatment goals and patient preference, as determined by the treating physician," he says.

Dr Khullar says, "In the near term, the route to Indian patients is Merck, or MSD as it is known here, bringing Lipfendra through CDSCO (Central Drugs Standard Control Organisation) approval. That process is not automatic and often requires local bridging data. The likely commercial pattern is the one we have already seen in this therapeutic space - Amgen partnered with Dr Reddy's Laboratories to market Repatha in India, and inclisiran has since come in through a similar arrangement. A multinational-plus-Indian-partner model is the most probable path."

Dr Kler is optimistic about a version of this pill being produced indigenously. "I would always prefer Indian pharmaceutical companies to make these drugs here because that will make them more affordable. Today, the Indian pharmaceutical industry has the capability to develop and manufacture these medicines. I have no doubt that we should encourage Indian companies to produce these drugs in the country," he says.

Dr Kler explains, "As far as patient acceptability is concerned, it depends on two factors. One is the ease of taking the medicine. Since this is a tablet, patients will accept it more readily than an injectable drug. The second factor is the cost. The price of the drug will matter a lot, especially for Indian patients. If the cost is reasonable and it is available as an oral medication, then certainly many patients will switch from injections to this drug."

"Removing the needle solves one barrier. It does not solve the price barrier, and we should not let the convenience story obscure that," says Dr Khullar. He also caveats, "This drug is not a solution to India's cholesterol problem. It is a very good tool for the subset of patients who are already diagnosed, already on maximum tolerated statin therapy, and still above target. That is a meaningful group and currently a badly served one. The much larger problem - that most Indians with high cholesterol have never had a lipid profile done - is not something a new molecule solves."

"Daily tablets are generally easier to incorporate into routine life than periodic injections. By removing the barrier associated with injectable therapy, an oral formulation may encourage better treatment adherence," explains Dr Malik. "Since its cholesterol-lowering efficacy appears comparable to injectable PCSK9 inhibitors, the key advantage lies in convenience, which often translates into better long-term cholesterol control."

Abating crisis

First of all, we must ensure that every individual gets a lipid profile done by the age of 20-25 years. We should start early rather than late, says Dr Kler. "In India, many people do not know their cholesterol or LDL levels until they suffer a heart attack. Annual health check-ups should begin at a young age so that we know a person's lipid profile early and can take appropriate action."

Echoing early screenings, advised by the Lipid Association of India between ages 18 to 20, Dr Khullar adds, "Treat to target, not treat and forget. Prescribing a statin is not the same as controlling cholesterol. A very large proportion of Indian patients on lipid-lowering therapy never have a follow-up lipid profile. We should be starting combination therapy upfront in high-risk patients rather than slowly escalating doses over years."

Dr Malik says that India needs greater public awareness about cholesterol, along with "routine screening of high-risk individuals, timely diagnosis, and evidence-based treatment. Improving access to effective therapies, while encouraging healthy eating, regular physical activity, tobacco cessation, and weight management, will be essential to reducing the country's growing burden of cardiovascular disease."

HEALTH CAPSULES

Tomatoes help in fatty liver disease

Daily consumption of raw tomatoes and tomato sauce for six weeks reduced hepatic steatosis, or the abnormal buildup of fat inside liver cells, among people with MASLD (Metabolic dysfunction-Associated Steatotic Liver Disease), according to a randomized controlled trial published in *Nutrients*.

One blood test for multiple diseases

UCLA researchers have created a blood test that can scan DNA signals for multiple cancers, liver diseases, and signs of organ damage-and even indicate where trouble may be developing. Early results suggest the approach could bring medicine closer to a single blood test capable of catching a wide range of diseases.

Kids' mental health hit hardest in heatwaves

A review published in the *International Journal of Epidemiology*, also show that adverse mental health outcomes increase by almost 1% for children with every 1 degree Celsius rise in daily temperature. Poor mental health outcomes increases 25% during heatwaves and by 1.5% in higher temperatures.

Nanobots for breast cancer therapy

Researchers at Institute of Nanoscience and Technology, Mohali have developed an advanced light-driven multifunctional nanobot for targeted breast cancer therapy. The technology could allow precise, externally controlled and minimally invasive treatment of breast tumours through localised therapeutic action.

Bhakti Samant

The protein confusion

New research says low protein aids longevity. What is the optimum intake?

FE FEATURES

NEW RESEARCH LINKS low protein intake with longevity. This is in contrast to the current fad of high protein diets and can be confusing for the lay person. So, what does an ideal meal look like? Bhakti Samant, chief dietician, Kokilaben Dhirubhai Ambani Hospital, Mumbai, says: "An ideal meal should focus on balance rather than simply being high or low in protein. A practical plate should include vegetables, whole grains or other complex carbohydrates, a good protein source, healthy fats, and adequate fibre. Protein can come from *dal*, beans, dairy, eggs, fish, or lean meat, depending on dietary preferences. The goal is a nutritionally diverse meal that supports overall health, not protein alone."

Does the advocated ratio of 1 g of protein per kg body weight hold for every individual?

No, protein requirements vary from individual to individual. Around 0.8-1 g/kg/day may be adequate for many healthy adults, but needs can increase with age, pregnancy, physical activity, illness, surgery, or recovery. Older adults and physically active individuals may require higher intake, while people with certain kidney conditions may need restrictions. Protein intake should, therefore, be individualised based on age, health status, lifestyle, and nutritional needs.

Indian protein sources like dal have low protein values. Are Indians at risk of low protein in traditional diets?

Dal is an important and nutritious source of plant protein, but the concern is whether the overall diet provides adequate protein. Traditional Indian meals can sometimes be dominated by cereals such as rice and wheat, with relatively smaller portions of pulses or other protein sources. Including adequate quantities of dal, beans, dairy, soy, nuts, and seeds, along with dietary variety, can help address protein gaps.

For a significant vegetarian population, what are good protein sources?

Vegetarians have several good protein options and do not necessarily require supplements. Pulses such as *moong*, *masoor*, *chana*, and *rajma*, along with soy, tofu, paneer, curd, milk, sprouts, nuts, and seeds, can contribute significantly to daily protein intake. The key is variety and distribution across meals. Combining cereals and pulses, while including dairy or soy where appropriate, can help provide a balanced amino-acid profile.

What are the harmful effects of a high-protein diet, especially powders and supplements?

The concern is not protein itself, but excessive or unnecessary intake. Very high protein consumption may displace fibre-rich foods and other essential nutrients, while people with kidney disease may need medically supervised protein intake. Protein powders can be useful when dietary requirements cannot be met through food, but they should not replace a balanced diet. Supplements should ideally be taken based on an individual's nutritional requirements and medical advice.

Opinion

SUNDAY, AUGUST 16, 2026

INDIA'S ECONOMIC AMBITIONS WILL INCREASINGLY BE DETERMINED NOT BY STRENGTH OF GOVERNANCE RULES ALONE, BUT BY THE QUALITY OF JUDGMENT EXERCISED INSIDE ITS BOARDROOMS

Next economic reform begins in boardroom

SRINATH SRIDHARAN

INDIA'S ECONOMIC AMBITIONS have never been larger. It wants to become a developed economy, emerge as a global manufacturing hub, attract long-term capital, lead in digital businesses and AI, and build globally competitive enterprises. Public policy has rightly focused on infrastructure, ease of doing business, manufacturing incentives, financial inclusion and technological capability. Yet one institution that will increasingly determine whether these ambitions endure receives remarkably little attention in our economic discourse: the corporate board.

This is surprising because every major economic transformation eventually converges in the boardroom. Decisions on capital allocation, technological adoption, acquisitions, succession, international expansion, cyber resilience and corporate culture ultimately reach one institution. The quality of those decisions will increasingly shape the quality of India's institutions.

Over the past two decades, India has quietly undertaken one of the world's most significant corporate governance transformations. Successive reforms have strengthened disclosure standards, empowered independent directors, expanded board committees, tightened oversight of related-party transactions and improved shareholder protection. These reforms have increased transparency, enhanced accountability and made Indian companies considerably more credible in the eyes of global investors.

But every reform journey eventually reaches a point where better rules alone produce diminishing returns. The next challenge is no longer writing better governance regulations. It is building better boards, in turn making institutions. That distinction has become more important because the environment boards are expected to govern has changed more in the past five years than in the previous two decades.

Board capability is no longer merely a corporate governance issue. It is becoming an essential component of national institutional infrastructure. We readily recognise physical, digital and financial infrastructure as engines of economic growth, yet the collective quality of judgment exercised inside corporate boardrooms may increasingly become one of the least visible, but most enduring, sources of national competitiveness. India wants to become a global manufacturing powerhouse just as supply chains are being redrawn by geopolitical rivalry. It wants to lead in artificial intelligence even as AI begins reshaping business models faster than organisations can adapt. Promoter-led enterprises are increasingly institutionalising themselves to attract professional talent, patient capital, and even monetise business. Indian companies are acquiring businesses overseas and competing as multinational enterprises rather than domestic champions. A decision to establish a manufacturing base is simultaneously a technology decision, a geopolitical decision, a capital allocation decision and a talent decision. Artificial intelligence is no longer merely an investment in software. It influences customer engagement, pricing, hiring, productivity and competitive strategy. International acquisitions increasingly expose boards to unfamiliar regulatory systems, cultural complexities and geopolitical risks. Family businesses transitioning towards institutional models must simultaneously preserve entrepreneurial agility while strengthening governance credibility. Increasingly, today's boards are expected to govern uncertainty. No regulation can prescribe how directors should balance long-term resilience against short-term market expectations. No governance code can teach a board how geopolitical fragmentation should influence capital allocation. No disclosure requirement can compel directors to challenge optimistic assumptions surrounding artificial intelligence or recognise emerging strategic vulnerabilities before they become obvious.

Corporate history is littered with companies that confused fashionable narratives with enduring strategy. The rush from globalisation to ESG, DEI and now AI reflects not merely evolving business priorities, but a recurring fear of being left behind. Boards must distinguish between strategic conviction and narrative-driven FOMO.

That requires moving beyond the conversation around independence and compliance towards a broader discussion on board capability. The most effective boards of the coming decade will not distinguish themselves merely through impressive résumés or impeccable regulatory compliance. They will distinguish themselves through the quality of their conversations, the diversity of perspectives they encourage and their willingness to question assumptions before circumstances force them to.

Artificial intelligence illustrates this challenge particularly well. Much of the public debate revolves around adoption, productivity and competitive advantage. The more difficult question is what AI means for board judgment. Directors increasingly upload confidential board papers into public generative AI tools to even generate questions for meetings. Besides creating obvious confidentiality concerns, this risks outsourcing the very judgment for which directors were appointed. Artificial intelligence should strengthen preparation, not substitute fiduciary responsibility. The danger is not that artificial intelligence replaces directors. It is that directors gradually outsource the very judgment they were appointed to exercise.

Companies invest heavily in leadership development, digital capability, and organisational transformation. Comparatively little investment is made in developing the board itself. Directors attend induction programmes and periodic updates, but very few boards deliberately strengthen their collective judgment. They rarely examine whether board culture encourages challenge, whether institutional memory survives director transitions or whether familiar habits have quietly replaced independent thinking. Boards, like companies, are institutions. They too require continuous rejuvenating.

The strongest boards of the future will, therefore, be those that learn collectively, revisit assumptions regularly and adapt before disruption makes adaptation unavoidable. They will understand that experience remains invaluable, but that experience without renewal gradually becomes inertia. Their competitive advantage will lie not in predicting every disruption correctly, but in responding to change faster than established assumptions permit.

India's first generation of governance reforms strengthened the architecture of accountability. The next generation must strengthen the capability of those entrusted to make that enterprise architecture work. The country's next economic reform begins with quality of corporate boards.

Srinath Sridharan is an author, corporate adviser & independent director on corporate boards

Golf's toughest battle isn't for the trophy

FAIRWAY FILES

Rahil Gangjee

BY THE TIME you read this, another Independence Day will have come and gone. I hope you all had a wonderful August 15 with family, friends and, if you were lucky, a round of golf thrown in. One of the things I love most about our game is how it brings together people from every walk of life. For four or five hours, we're all equal—CEOs, students, professionals, weekend hackers—all chasing the same little white ball and, more often than not, the same nearest-to-the-pin prize! That's the beauty of golf. It teaches respect, camaraderie and healthy competition, values that make sport such a powerful unifier.

I've travelled the world playing golf. Apart from the domestic tour events, I've played the DP World Tour events, Asian Tour events and enough pro-ams to last a lifetime. And after all these years, I've reached one undeniable conclusion. The fiercest competition in golf isn't for a Major. It isn't for a Rolex. It isn't even for the Ryder Cup. It's for the nearest-to-the-pin prize sponsored by the local perfume shop.

Nothing—and I mean absolutely nothing—transforms otherwise sensible golfers into raging competitors faster than a volunteer announcing, *"Current leader... 8 feet, 11 inches."* The prize could be a tiny bottle of cologne, a coffee mug, a keychain, a toaster, or a dinner voucher that expires before you've even digested the starter. It doesn't matter. Someone is prepared to risk a shoulder injury trying to win it.

Corporate golf days are my favourite. For the first 14 holes, nobody seems remotely interested in the golf. The CEO is answering calls, the CFO is discussing quarterly numbers, someone is asking whether the buffet has *biryani*, and another chap has already declared, "Boss, I'm just here for networking." Then the group reaches the designated par-3. Phones disappear. Conversations stop. Suddenly everyone becomes Viktor Hovland.

The same bloke who has made four air-swings all day now asks everyone to maintain complete silence because he's "visualising the shot." Visualising? Mate... you've just made a 10 on the previous hole. The volunteer holding the clipboard instantly becomes the most important person on the golf course. "Who's leading?" "Eight feet." "No... mine's closer." "Measure it properly." I've genuinely seen more heated discussions over nearest-to-the-pin than over relief from an embedded ball.

And once somebody knocks it close, he doesn't enjoy the remaining holes. He spends them monitoring everyone else's. Every few holes he'll casually drift towards the scoring area pretending to stretch, only to check if anyone has bettered his effort. I've watched grown men who can't remember their wedding anniversary recall, to the nearest inch, exactly where every nearest-to-the-pin marker stood throughout the afternoon.

Professionals aren't any different. We just pretend we're more sophisticated. One of the biggest myths in golf is that tour players don't gamble during practice rounds. Absolute nonsense. If anything, Monday and Tuesday practice rounds can become more competitive than the tournament itself. Players regularly have money games because, as Vijay Singh famously believed, you prepare better when something is riding on the outcome. Phil Mickelson has never hidden his love for side bets either. One of his favourite lines has been, *"If you can't make a putt for a couple of hundred bucks, how are you going to make one for a million?"*

Golf brings together people from all walks of life — chasing the same ball and the same prize

I've been lucky enough to witness a few of these games. Nobody gives strokes. Nobody hands out compliments. It's amazing how quickly friendships become... flexible. A relaxed Tuesday practice round suddenly feels like the final round of The Open because someone has put fifty dollars on closest-to-the-pin. I've seen players who couldn't care less about a casual chipping contest spend five minutes discussing wind direction and landing areas with their caddie because lunch was riding on one swing. Miss the shot and your friends won't sympathise. They'll laugh, collect the money and remind you about it for the next six months.

One of the funniest sights on tour is the player who insists he wasn't really trying. He hits one to three feet, pockets the money and shrugs, "Ah... got lucky." Really? Then why did you spend three minutes discussing the breeze before choosing between an eight and a nine iron? The acting deserves an Oscar.

Club golfers have their own version of this theatre. The shot gets better every time the story is retold. At the prize presentation it was five feet. Over dinner it becomes three. By the following weekend it "nearly went in." A month later, someone hearing the story for the first time is convinced it actually was a hole-in-one. Golf memories improve much faster than handicaps.

One of the funniest things I ever saw happened at a club where two players couldn't decide whose ball was actually closer for a tiny closest-to-the-pin wager. One gentleman calmly pulled out his laser rangefinder... on the green... to settle a bet worth less than the coffee they were about to drink. Apparently, dignity wasn't included in the stakes.

> Golfers rarely remember what they scored in the corporate event, but they'll recall flushing a seven-iron to four feet and walking away with a bottle of aftershave worth ₹799

Maybe organisers should stop spending money on expensive prizes. Forget luxury hampers, golf bags and fancy gadgets. Announce that the nearest-to-the-pin winner gets a steel tiffin box, a packet of pickle or a pressure cooker. I promise participation won't drop by even one golfer. Because the prize has never really mattered.

It's the story that matters. Golfers rarely remember what they scored in the corporate event, but they'll vividly recall flushing a seven-iron to four feet on the 16th and walking away with a bottle of aftershave worth ₹799. I've seen players win tournaments with less emotion than someone collecting a coffee mug for nearest-to-the-pin. The photographs are taken, the chest swells with pride and, for one brief moment, they genuinely feel like Masters champions.

That's the wonderful absurdity of golf. We can shoot 82, lose three balls, miss half the fairways and four-putt twice, yet drive home delighted because one swing was perfect. Maybe that's why we keep coming back. Every golfer dreams of shooting par. But secretly, we're all just hoping to hear those magical words at the prize distribution: *"And the nearest-to-the-pin winner is..."*

Rahil Gangjee is a professional golfer, sharing through this column what life on a golf course is like

Kudos, cockroaches

FIFTH COLUMN

TAVLEEN SINGH

ON INDIA'S EIGHTIETH birthday, all our political leaders need to hang their heads in shame. Or to use the inimitable Hindi expression, drown themselves in a handful of water. It should mortify them that it is young people who have come forward on this day that we celebrate Independence Day, to tell them what their priorities should be. These young people have reminded them, and us, that the money and time wasted on building a new parliament house and a new residence for the prime minister could have been better spent in repairing rural schools.

The Cockroach Janta Party has announced that this August 15, they will begin a campaign to repair rural schools. To make their case, they have spent the past week posting pictures of village schools on social media. In these pictures, we see classrooms with crumbling walls and bare floors. We also see school toilets so filthy that it is hard to believe that little children, and especially little girls, will be made to use these sickening hellholes. The pictures surprised me not at all because I have seen schools exactly like these in states across India. But especially in Uttar Pradesh and Bihar.

In an odd coincidence, I was brooding over these things while gathering my thoughts for this column, when the chief minister of Uttar Pradesh popped up on my television to make an ugly, divisive, dangerous speech. Since Pakistan's Independence Day is now Partition Day in India, Yogi Adityanath thought it appropriate to remind young Indians about those trains that came from Pakistan filled with dead bodies. As if rehearsing for next year's election, he said that it was the Congress Party that was responsible for Partition and that if Narendra Modi had been prime minister, this would never have happened.

In making this speech, he accidentally revealed why, in 12 years of being the prime minister, Modi has failed to improve the appalling state of government schools or end corruption in national examinations. He and his chief ministers have been too busy doing other things like reminding young Indians about the horrors of the past in which the villains were always Muslims and the victims always Hindus. No country that wallows in the wounds of history ever succeeds in building a better future. Very sad that it has taken the cockroaches to remind us of this. So, kudos to you cockroaches.

Is there anything then that can be truly celebrated on India's eightieth birthday? When I asked my new best friend Claude this question, it trawled through its artificial intelligence and concluded that democracy and the peaceful transfer of power were some of the things to celebrate. Not needing to import foodgrain, as we once used to, is another thing we should celebrate, and the reduction in extreme poverty from 45% in 1990 to less than 15% today is also an achievement unless we compare this with our old enemy China. Until 1980, we were growing pretty much at the same rate, but the Chinese economy is five times India's now, and 800 million Chinese are out of poverty. Literacy is 97% compared to our 70%.

It is shameful that when we talk about 70% of our population being literate, we mean literally that. When average Indian children complete their education in a government school, they can count in a basic sort of way and read in a basic sort of way. That is all. This is why I agree totally with the Cockroach Janta Party's new campaign. Nothing is more important than fixing the serious defects in government schools. There are those who like to romanticise about how wonderful these schools were once and how they deteriorated since Modi became prime minister. This is not true. They were always schools only in name. But Modi can certainly be blamed for not getting his chief ministers to make changes on a war footing.

Every Independence Day the thing that saddens me most is the sight of small children, barefoot and in rags, standing at streetlights in Delhi and Mumbai selling limp, sodden national flags. Sometimes the children are so small that their hands barely reach the windows of passing cars and sometimes their clothes and flags are so soaked that they look as if they have spent hours in the rain. I always pay extra for the flags, hoping that if the money is not stolen by older children, the little ones will be able to celebrate India's birthday with a hot meal.

Every year I have waited for our political leaders to notice these desperately poor children and try and do something for them. It has never happened. This year the leader of the Cockroach Janta Party not only noticed them but declared angrily that these children should be in school, not on the streets. It warmed my heart to hear him say this, and although I am not in a celebratory mood on India's 80th birthday, I continue to hope that there will come an Independence Day when instead of empty patriotic slogans from our political leaders we will have younger leaders who know what India's priorities should really be.

What tops my list is the miserable state of our children. May an Independence Day come when on the streets of our cities we no longer see little children selling Indian flags just to make enough for a celebratory hot meal.

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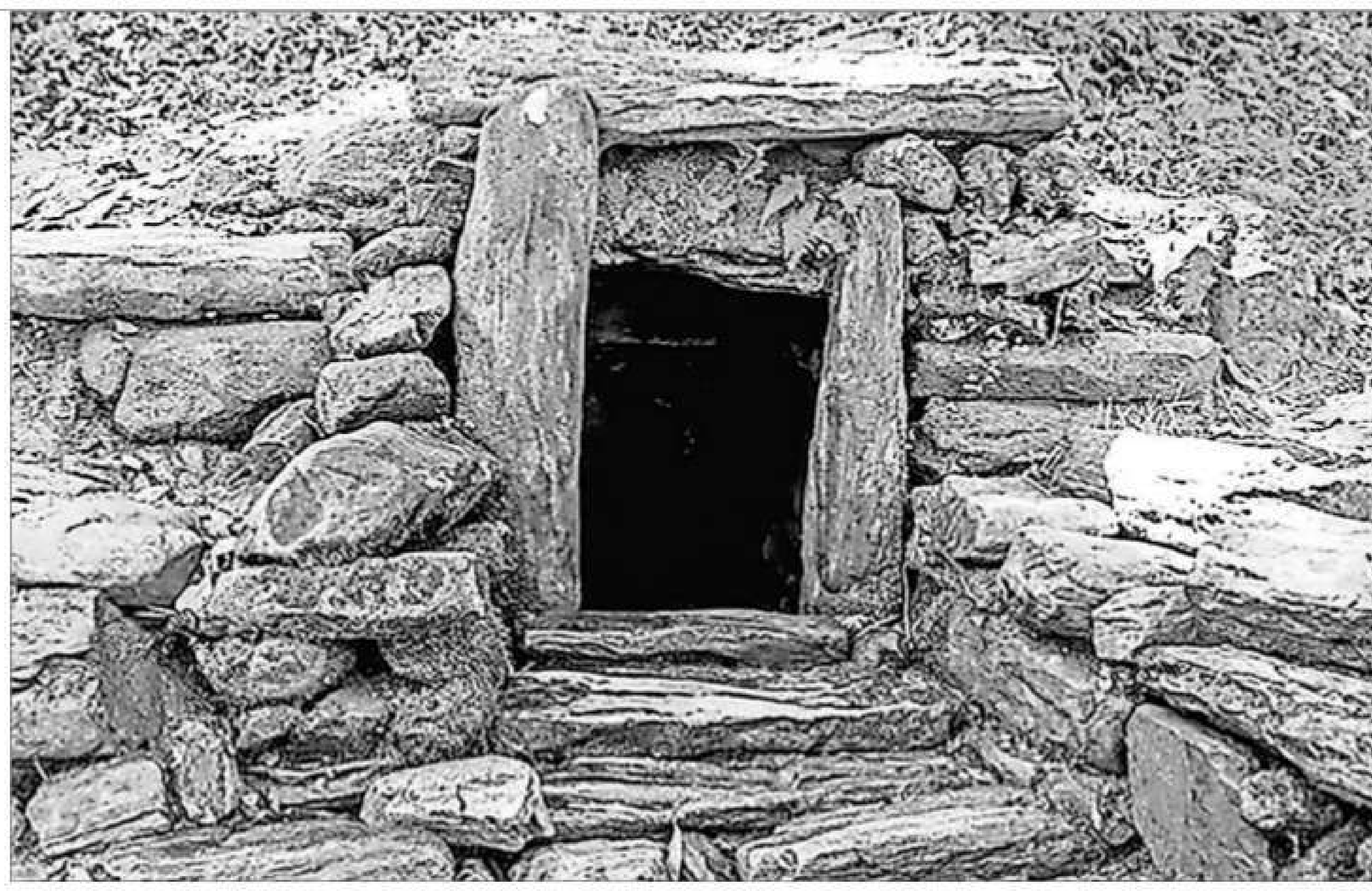
Mind & Games

SUNDAY, AUGUST 16, 2026



Local residents use traditional springs, locally known as a dibri, and seal it after use

Can restoring forests save HIMALAYAN WATER?

Erratic rainfall is weakening the natural systems. Himachal Pradesh is responding by restoring springs, forests and watersheds

SURINDER KUMAR

IN LUDERA VILLAGE of Himachal Pradesh's Chamba district, the signs of water stress appeared long before 'climate change' became a buzzword. The district lies on the banks of Ravi. For generations, residents moving livestock to higher-altitude grazing grounds during summer months depended on small natural springs for drinking water.

"When we take our cattle to the *dhar* during the summer months, rivers are too far away," says Balkrishan Singh. "Earlier, water was available throughout the season, but many of these sources are now drying up."

These mountain springs have sustained lives and livelihoods for generations. In addition to providing water for livestock, they have irrigated small farms and supplied drinking water to villages – long before pipelines reached the Himalayas. Today, many of those springs are becoming less reliable, even as the state records episodes of unusually heavy rainfall. Longer dry spells followed by intense cloudbursts mean less water seeps slowly into the ground to recharge the underground aquifers that feed Himalayan springs. Instead, much of it rushes downhill as runoff, leaving communities with both floods and water shortages. Sustained groundwater recharge, by contrast, depends on slower and more evenly distributed rainfall.

Himachal Pradesh is responding with a different kind of climate adaptation. Rather than focusing only on delivering more water through pipes and storage tanks, it is beginning to restore the natural landscapes that produce water in the first place. From reviving traditional springs and protecting recharge zones to restoring forests, ponds and watersheds, the state is testing whether nature-based solutions can build long-term water security in the warming mountains. The transition is still uneven and far from complete. But across districts from Chamba to Lahaul-Spiti, communities are already seeing how restoring ecosystems can make mountain water systems more resilient.

Changing rainfall patterns

The changes observed in villages such as Ludera are reflected across much of Himachal Pradesh. While annual rainfall may remain close to normal in some years, the way it falls has changed. Between 2010 and 2024, Himachal Pradesh experienced sharp swings in rainfall, ranging from severe pre-monsoon deficits to episodes of extreme precipitation. The pattern continued in 2025.

While high-altitude districts such as Lahaul-Spiti and Kinnaur experienced rainfall deficits during parts of the year, districts including Shimla, Kullu, Bilaspur and Hamirpur recorded exceptionally heavy rainfall during intense weather events. The result was a growing imbalance: more runoff during storms, but less groundwater recharge between them. These sharp swings expose a fundamental weakness in mountain hydrology. Heavy rain may fill rivers and trigger floods, but it does little to recharge groundwater if it falls too quickly. Springs depend on slow, sustained infiltration through soil and rock, not short bursts of intense rainfall.

The consequences have become increasingly visible. In 2018, Shimla faced a severe water crisis that left many residents receiving water only once every eight days, while authorities appealed to tourists to stay away during the peak summer season. The crisis exposed the vulnerability of Himalayan towns to changing rain patterns and highlighted the need to look beyond water distribution systems.

Restoring nature's infra

For decades, governments approached water scarcity by bringing water to people. Climate change is forcing Himachal Pradesh to also restore the landscapes that produce water. The shift marks an important change in thinking. Pipelines, storage tanks and distribution networks can transport water, but they cannot replenish the springs, streams and aquifers on which water supply infrastructure depends. "The government often starts water-supply schemes wherever water is available and transports it through pipelines, but pays little attention to protecting the source itself," said Kulbhushan Upmanyu, president of the grassroots collective Himalaya Niti Abhiyan. "Water conservation should begin by identifying recharge zones, understanding groundwater movement through hydrological and geological studies, and protecting forests and vegetation that sustain springs."

The approach, called springshed restoration, doesn't treat a spring as an isolated water source. Rather, it restores the forests, soils, wetlands and recharge zones that capture rainwater and allow it to slowly percolate underground before emerging as springs months later.

The work has been carried out by the Jal Shakti Department and the respective Gram Panchayats, using funds under various initiatives such as the Jal Shakti Abhiyan's Catch the Rain campaign, the Watershed Development Component of the Pradhan Mantri Krishi Sinchayi Yojana and the Climate Change Adaptation in Rural Areas of India. Work involves clearing water channels, building or cleaning up recharge pits to collect rainwater, restoring ponds and storage tanks, and protecting the source of the spring. In Una district, the authorities have begun restoring traditional ponds that had fallen into neglect after piped water became widespread. Instead of applying a standard template, engineers assessed each pond's geography, catchment area, water source, pollution status and local needs before designing site-specific restoration measures.

According to Naresh Dhiman, superintending engineer with the Jal Shakti Department in Una, this scientific approach is what distinguishes the project. Each pond's geographic location, catchment area, water source, pollution status and local needs were studied, and technical solutions were prepared accordingly. Once completed, the restored ponds are expected to recharge nearly 5.8 million cubic metres of groundwater annually while increasing local water availability by an estimated 0.90 million litres a day – enough to meet the daily needs of 9,000 people. Residents have adapted similar practices. Satya Devi of Kalwara village of Chamba says the community cleans its traditional spring only lightly because excessive digging can alter its natural flow. Once the small collection pit, locally known as a dibri, fills with water, villagers channel the overflow into a small pond for livestock.

In Khurik panchayat of Spiti block, traditional water bodies and storage tanks were restored under the Catch the Rain campaign in 2024. Panchayat Pradhan Dechen Angmo told Climate Action Live that the restoration has improved water availability during the summer months and now supports drinking water for around 650 residents through household tap connections. Kalzang Dolma of Margo Rangrik village says the difference has been noticeable. "Earlier, the storage tanks would run dry by late summer, but after restoration they continue to supply water throughout the season." Across Lahaul-Spiti, where winter freezes and rugged terrain complicate water supply, traditional springs remain indispensable despite official claims of universal tap-water coverage under the Har Ghar Jal programme. The programme was launched by the Ministry of Jal Shakti in 2019 with the aim of providing tap water to every family by 2024. Himachal Pradesh too claims 100% "Functional Household Tap Connection" provision under the Mission, which seeks to provide tap connections in rural areas.

Nirmala Devi, Pradhan of Salgran Panchayat, told *Climate Action Live* that several wards are not yet covered. Even in areas where the scheme has been implemented, water does not always reach regularly. During the winter when pipelines freeze, "springs remain our primary source of water for domestic use and kitchen gardening," she said.

> SPRINGS ARE BECOMING LESS RELIABLE EVEN AS STATE RECORDS EPISODES OF HEAVY RAINFALL

The benefits of restoring springs become clear in Tingret Panchayat of Lahaul-Spiti, where multiple natural springs have been rejuvenated and channelled into a common village source through joint efforts by the Jal Shakti Vibhag (water department) of Himachal state and local communities.

Although every household in Chhaling village has a tap connection, the village is not yet connected to a regular piped water supply, with nearly 150 residents dependent on a public tap.

"Earlier, people had to carry water from the public tap or directly from the springs whenever the supply was disrupted," Panchayat Pradhan Anita Kumari said. "Now, when water is available at the rejuvenated source, households can pipe it to their homes, making access much easier." The restored springs have also improved irrigation for kitchen gardens and agricultural fields, supporting the cultivation of fruits and vegetables during the growing season.

However, spring rejuvenation alone cannot solve the Himalayan water crisis. While restoring recharge zones and improving groundwater infiltration can revive declining springs, Anand Giri, assistant professor at IIT Mandi says, long-term water security will also depend on consistent and long-term watershed restoration, forest conservation, climate-resilient agriculture, disaster-resilient infrastructure and water management.

The experience of villages such as Ludera, Khurik and Tingret suggests that restoring springs and watersheds can make communities more resilient to a changing climate. The bigger challenge is scaling those efforts across an entire mountain state. Himachal Pradesh has made a start. According to the Economic Survey 2025-26, the state has completed 17 restoration works under the Watershed Development Component Plus pilot programme, while 1,488 natural resource management works have been implemented to improve soil moisture, reduce erosion and enhance groundwater recharge. NABARD has also sanctioned 22 springshed development projects across 10 districts to strengthen drinking water and irrigation security.

Under the WDC-PMKSY 2.0 framework, 417 springs have been identified for restoration across the state. Work has been completed on 178 springs, while another 130 are under restoration. More than a quarter of the identified springs, 109 in all, are yet to see work begin.

Scientific planning also remains a bottleneck. Although the Department of Land Resources has identified 79 additional springs for pilot springshed management, hydrogeological surveys essential for understanding groundwater movement have so far been completed in only 15 project areas. According to the State Disaster Management Authority's Memorandum of Damages, Himachal Pradesh has suffered disaster-related losses of around ₹46,000 crore over the past four years, equivalent to roughly 4% of its Gross State Domestic Product each year.

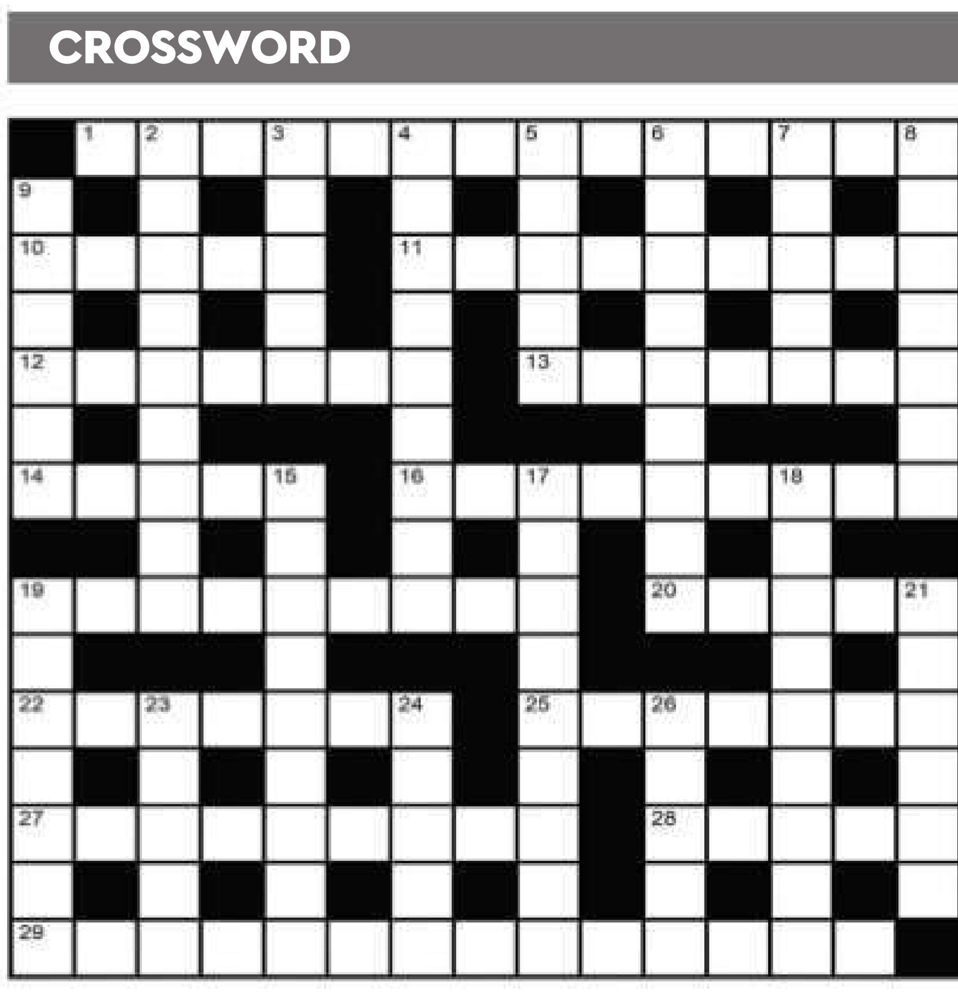
The lessons extend well beyond Himachal Pradesh. Across the Indian Himalayas, millions of people depend on springs for drinking water, farming and livestock.

As climate change alters rainfall patterns and weakens the natural systems that sustain these water sources, mountain communities will need to look beyond conventional infrastructure. Pipelines, reservoirs and treatment plants will remain essential. But they can only distribute the water that nature provides. Protecting forests, restoring watersheds and reviving springs offer a complementary approach by helping landscapes capture, store and gradually release water. As Himachal Pradesh is discovering, the most resilient water infrastructure may not always be built from concrete. Sometimes, it begins with restoring the ecosystem itself.

For villagers like Balkrishan Singh of Ludera in Chamba district, the measure of success is far simpler than rainfall statistics or programme targets. It is whether the spring on the grazing trail still flows when summer arrives. As climate change reshapes the Himalayas, restoring the landscapes that feed those springs may prove to be one of the region's most important climate adaptations.

The piece is published in arrangement with Climate Action Live https://www.climateaction.live/

CROSSWORD



ACROSS

1 In a straight line, or Jeffrey Archer's famous novel? (2,3,4,5)
10 City in Gujarat famous for its silk mills (5)
11 ___ to : coming into the mind of? (9)
12 Pawnbroker's premises? (3-4)
13 Penitence or repentance (7)
14 A fashion or style (5)
16 Made easy or relieved of doubts? (3,2,4)
19 One making a prayer (9)
20 Fowl's perch (5)
22 Coffee mugs and __ __ (3,4)
25 Dutch bank (3,4)
27 Tax on tax (9)
28 Former Indian cricketer ____ Azad (5)
29 It is Sensex in short (9,5)

DOWN

2 To which old iron is consigned, for instance (5-4)
3 Its Vodafone now (5)
4 The result of a storm brewing in the oceanic region, perhaps? (6,3)
5 Academy Award (5)
6 US Auto giant __ __ Co (4,5)
7 More chilly or colder (5)
8 Propose or recommend (7)
9 Hole for fire residue - "at hips" anagram? (6)
15 Founder of Reliance Group Mr. ___ Ambani (9)
17 A private conversation between two people (4-1-4)
18 Business on the Internet (1-8)
19 Painters or sculptors? (7)
21 Consumed or ingested (4,2)
23 Area of the airport where planes are parked which may be used for loading and unloading of aircraft (5)
24 "Reg is" changed into a Spaniard ? (5)
26 Makers of Coolpix cameras (5)

KAKURO

In Kakuro sum puzzles, the numbers in the black squares refer to the SUMS of the digits, which you are to fill into the empty spaces directly below or to the right of the black square containing the number. No zeroes are used here, only the digits one through nine. An important point: A digit cannot appear more than once in any particular digit combination.

BIZ QUIZ

1. Which Indian airline is planning to induct 100 new planes over the next 2 years?
2. Which quick-commerce's warehouse in Bengaluru has been sealed over hygiene issues ?
3. Which Indian fashion designer has joined hands with MET to create jewellery and clothing by its art collection?

BUZZ WORD

The Buzz Word is a substitution cipher in which one letter stands for another.

If you think that X equals O, it will equal O throughout the puzzle. Single letters, short words and words using an apostrophe give you clues to locating vowels. Solution is by trial and error.

Today's clue: KBX equals HOB

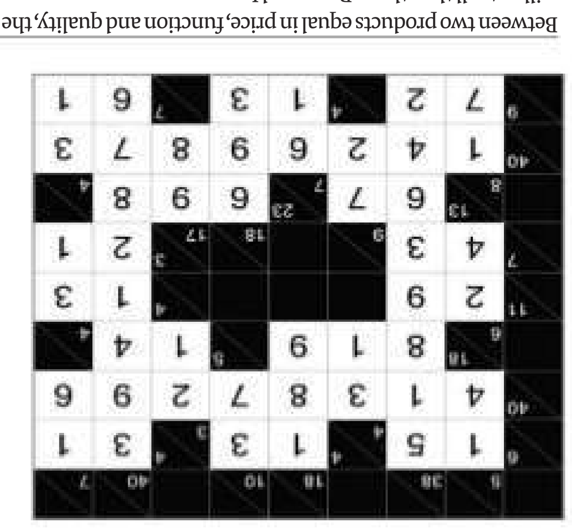
Xpmrppq mrb jabwilmt pyicv oq jaolp, niqlmobq cqw yicvoms, mkp xpmmpa vbbgoqz rovv bim tpvv mkp bmkpa. - Acsubqw Vbprs

ANSWERS

1. Air India 2. Zepto 3. Sabyasachi Mukherjee

Between two products equal in price, function and quality, the better looking will out sell the other. - Raymond Loewy

SOLUTIONS



BRIDGE BOUTS L SUBRAMANIAN

LIVING DANGEROUSLY IN MATCH-POINTS

Today's deal is from a match-point event that had twenty sixs tables.

Dlr: West
Vul: N-S

West:
S 2
H K 6 5
D K J T 4
C A Q 9 6 2

South:
S K 9
H 9 8 4
D A 9 7 6 5 2
C J 7

W	N	E	South
1D	1H	1S	Pass
2C	2H	3C	3H
dbl	All Pass		

After some competitive bidding, west was faced with a decision of whether to bid further or not. He chose to double the opponents, for they were vulnerable.

Contract: 3H by north; doubled by west.

How the play went: East led the **C**K. West overtook it with the ace and shifted to the **S**2. Dummy played the eight and partner the seven. Declarer won with the nine and led the nine of hearts from hand. East won with the ace, and gave west a spade ruff. West cashed **H**K and exited in **C**Q. Declarer ruffed and had to lose a diamond in the end, for down one and + 200 to E-W. Result: 70% to E-W.

The complete hands were:

North:
S A J T 8
H Q J T 7 3 2
D Q 8
C 4

West:
S 2
H K 6 5
D K J T 4
C A Q 9 6 2

East:
S Q 7 6 5 4 3
H A
D 3
C K T 8 5 3

South:
S K 9
H 9 8 4
D A 9 7 6 5 2
C J 7

Discussion: You may wonder why only 70%. Simple. Because E-W can make 5C. East has too many clubs. So, it was not good bridge to sit for the double and wiser decision would have been to pull it out to 4C or bid 5C.

There were mixed results:

4S - 2	8 tables
5C =	7 tables
3H =	9 tables
3H dbl -1	1 table
2D = 1	1 table

Playing match-points, you take a big risk whenever you make a close double. Make sure your defense is sharp. Not sloppy!

It was good bridge by NS, not doubling 4S on the many tables where it was bid, as you can see 5C is cold for EW!

LEXICON

GENERICIDE

■ *n.* The process by which a brand name becomes a generic name for an entire product category.

Datalytics Inc. of Dayton, Ohio, an on-line business service firm, has added Markwatch, "to help you detect potential infringement, dilution, tarnishment and genericide" of trademarks.
—Deborah Shapley, "Corporate Web Police Hunt Down E-Pirates," *The New York Times*, May 19, 1997

CORPORATE BRIEFS

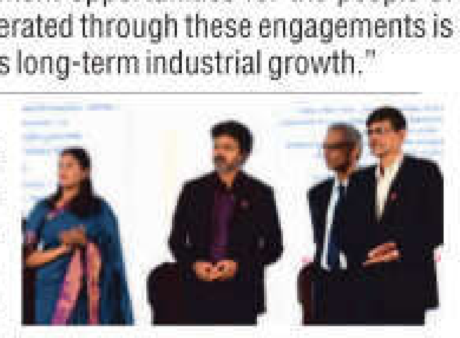
CIIC Successfully Concludes 5th Mega Demo Day

Following its successful execution on August 5, the Crescent Innovation & Incubation Council (CIIC) has announced the completion and key milestones of its 5th Mega Demo Day – Startup Showcase 2026. Hosted at the B.S. Abdur Rahman Crescent Institute of Science and Technology in Vandalur, the event successfully brought together startups, investors, industry leaders, innovators, mentors, and ecosystem partners for a day focused on creating meaningful opportunities for emerging ventures. Operating under the theme "Celebrating Innovation | Connecting Ecosystems | Creating Impact," the fifth edition marked an important milestone in CIIC's journey. Evolving beyond a traditional showcase, this year's event successfully facilitated direct, high-value connections between entrepreneurs, investors, industry veterans, and the wider innovation ecosystem. A major highlight of the concluded event was Fundora 2.0, CIIC's dedicated startup pitching arena. This focused platform brought together 30 startups and over 100 investors who traveled from across India to participate. Thirty founders were able to present their ventures directly to these potential financial backers, creating a highly concentrated environment to showcase their businesses, explore active funding opportunities, and build strategic, nationwide relationships. Speaking during the event, Dr. M. Parvez Alam, Executive Director, CIIC & AIC-CIIC said, "The overwhelming response to this year's showcase proved that our efforts are translating into real-world success. By bringing together 150 startups and over 120 investors under one roof, we celebrated a massive milestone: the total external capital raised by our startups has now quadrupled, reaching ₹400 crore."

CM Majhi returns to Odisha with ₹66,392 Crore Investment and 54,135 Jobs After Two-Day Delhi-NCR Visit

Odisha's two-day investment outreach in Delhi, led by Chief Minister Mohan Charan Majhi, concluded today with a strong response from industry, generating investment proposals worth ₹66,392 crore, with the potential to create 54,135 employment opportunities. Following the successful Odisha Food Pro 2026, the outreach brought together leading investors and industry representatives through high-level one-on-one meetings, sector-focused roundtable discussions and a visit to the Haier manufacturing facility in Noida. The engagements focused on translating industry interest into investments, strengthening manufacturing and value chains, and creating new employment opportunities for the people of Odisha. The two-day industrial outreach is part of the State Government's continued efforts to accelerate industrial growth in line with the vision of Prime Minister Narendra Modi for Purvodaya and the accelerated development of Eastern India. The Chief Minister said, "Odisha is building an ecosystem where industries can grow, create jobs and build long-term value. Our focus is not only on attracting investment, but also on creating employment, strengthening local supply chains and opening new opportunities for the youth of Odisha. We want investors to see Odisha as a reliable and long-term partner for growth."
Minister for Industries, Sampad Chandra Swain, said, "The response from industry in Delhi-NCR reflects the growing confidence in Odisha's investment ecosystem. Our priority is to facilitate investors, strengthen sector-specific value chains and create more employment opportunities for the people of Odisha. We are working to ensure that the investment interest generated through these engagements is converted into projects on the ground and contributes to the State's long-term industrial growth."

TNPL - Tissue Paper Mill



Tamil Nadu Newsprint and Papers Limited (TNPL), a Government of Tamil Nadu Enterprise, has entered a new phase of growth with the establishment of its state-of-the-art Tissue Paper Manufacturing Facility at its Unit II campus in Mondipatti, Tiruchirappalli District. The new facility marks TNPL's strategic foray into the hygienic tissue paper segment and further strengthens its position as one of India's leading integrated pulp and paper manufacturers. With this initiative, TNPL has earned the distinction of being the first Mill in South India to commence tissue paper manufacturing. The TNPL Tissue Paper Manufacturing Facility, located at Kagitha Nagar, Mondipatti, Tiruchirappalli District, was inaugurated by Chief Minister of Tamil Nadu, C. Joseph Vijay, from the Vetri Tamil Nadu Investors' Meet held in Chennai. The occasion was graced by the Minister for Industries, S. Keerthana; Dr. M. Saikumar IAS, Chief Secretary; Kumar Jayant, IAS, Additional Chief Secretary / Chairman and Managing Director, Tamil Nadu Newsprint and Papers Limited; and Dr. S. Vijayakumar, IAS, Additional Chief Secretary, Industries, Investment Promotion and Commerce Department. TNPL's Tissue Paper Project has been implemented at its Unit II at Kagitha Nagar, Mondipatti, Tiruchirappalli District, at an investment of ₹350 crore, net of GST. Equipped with advanced world-class technology, the facility has an installed production capacity of 100 metric tonnes per day and manufactures four categories of premium-quality tissue paper under the 'LUMEA' brand - Facial, Napkin, Towel and Toilet Tissue.

ICL Fincorp NCD issue, offering up to 12.25% effective yield

Upholding a 35-year tradition of fiscal reliability, ICL Fincorp presented its latest public offering of Secured Redeemable Non-Convertible Debentures (NCDs), commencing on 10th August 2026. Providing an effective yield of up to 12.25%, this instrument is meticulously structured for discerning investors seeking stability and security combined with flexible tenures. Following the exceptional reception of our preceding NCD offerings, we express our profound appreciation for the unwavering trust placed in us by our investors. This relationship remains the cornerstone of our commitment to crafting stable, sophisticated financial solutions. The NCD issue will remain open until 21st August 2026 and is rated CRISIL BBB-/STABLE. Each NCD carries a face value of ₹1,000. The issue offers 10 schemes (10 ISINs), with tenures of 13, 24, 36, 60, and 72 months, with monthly, annual, and cumulative payout options, with interest rates ranging from 10.00% to 12.25%. The minimum application size is ₹10,000, (10NCDs) & in multiples of 1 NCD thereafter. ICL Fincorp stands as a pillar of trust under the stewardship of Adv. K.G. Anilkumar, Chairman & Managing Director. The institutional footprint extends across thirteen states: Kerala, Tamil Nadu, Andhra Pradesh, Telangana, Karnataka, Maharashtra, Odisha, Gujarat, West Bengal, Goa, Delhi, Rajasthan and Bihar, rapidly scaling toward a pan-India presence. Furthermore, our subsidiary, Salem Erode Investments—a BSE-listed non-banking financial company (NBFC) augments our operational strength. The new NCD issue, aims to help customers in financial growth, security, and long-term value.

Tamil Nadu inks 97 MoUs worth ₹67,542 crore, eyes over 1 lakh jobs

The Tamil Nadu government signed MoUs for 97 projects across automotive, renewable energy, life sciences, electronics, R&D and data centres, involving investments of ₹67,542 crore and creating employment opportunities for more than one lakh people.The Vetri Tamil Nadu Investment Conclave 2026, presided over by Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C Joseph Vijay, marks the first major investment drive since the Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK) government came to power three months ago. Industries Minister S Keerthana said Tamil Nadu was targeting becoming a US$1.5-trillion economy by 2036. She said the state's cumulative investment commitments during the first 100 days of the TVK government would cross ₹1 lakh crore through 104 MoUs, generating 1,21,788 direct and indirect jobs. The investment commitments include a mix of greenfield and brownfield projects. Sector-wise data centres accounted for the largest share of investment commitments at ₹26,417 crore, followed by automotive at ₹17,073 crore and renewable energy at ₹15,787 crore. Critical engineering projects attracted commitments worth ₹9,525 crore, while multisector projects accounted for ₹8,010 crore. The textile sector attracted commitments worth ₹7,871 crore, with the projects expected to create 24,876 jobs. Among the marquee investors, Daimler India Commercial Vehicles, the maker of BharatBenz trucks and buses, announced an additional investment of approximately ₹4,000 crore. The investment will take DICV's cumulative investment in India to more than ₹14,500 crore.
The Hinduja Group announced plans to invest ₹2,500 crore across its businesses, including renewable energy, electric mobility, automotive, financial services, energy, battery charging infrastructure and digital mobility solutions. Ashok Hinduja, Chairman, Hinduja Group of Companies (India), said, "Our ₹2,500 crore commitment is a statement of our confidence in Tamil Nadu and our desire to participate in its next phase of growth." Titan Company will invest ₹1,000 crore in Hosur to expand facilities for premium watches, jewellery and automation equipment for its electronics business, creating 1,200 jobs. Lucas TVS, a homegrown automotive and EV components major, will invest ₹2,500 crore across multiple facilities in Hosur. Australia's AVID Group, a mining and infrastructure conglomerate, has proposed an investment of approximately ₹15,000 crore in Tamil Nadu over the next five years, with an initial MoU worth ₹7,000 crore, making it one of the largest multi-sector FDI commitments at the conclave. A total of 30 foreign-headquartered projects represent ₹22,268 crore in FDI commitments and are expected to generate 38,357 jobs. The investments come from 16 source countries, including Australia, Germany, Japan, France, Singapore, South Korea, and the United States.

Genrobotics to invest Rs 150 cr in Tamil Nadu to set up robotics hub

Kerala-based deep-tech robotics company Genrobotics will be investing Rs 150 crore in five years in Tamil Nadu to establish a high-end robotics exporting facility in the state. The company signed a Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) with the Government of Tamil Nadu in this regard in Chennai today in the presence Chief Minister C Joseph Vijay and Minister for Industries, Govt. of Tamil Nadu, S Keerthana. Genrobotics Chief Operating Officer Nikhil N.P and Director Rashid K signed the MoU and exchanged it with CEO of Guidance Tamil Nadu Deepak Jacob IAS. Chief Secretary of Govt. of Tamil Nadu, Dr M Sai Kumar IAS and Additional Chief Secretary, Industries, Dr S Vijayakumar IAS, were also present on the occasion. The project comes as part of the company's plans to scale up manufacture and operational footprint across the country. Genrobotics scripted history by developing the world's first robotic scavenger Bandicoot, which has been integrated into the urban sanitation systems of several states across India. The Tamil Nadu project marks one of Genrobotics' largest single commitments to date and reinforces its push into international markets across sanitation, industrial, medical, and defense robotics. Noting that Tamil Nadu offers the scale to meet growing international demand, Shri Nikhil said the investment reflects the firm's confidence in the state's manufacturing ecosystem and its ambition to build a scalable export base to serve fast-growing robotics demand across the Middle East and MENA region and Southeast Asia.

IMA Chennai Chapter Leadership Talk & Networking Event

The IMA Chennai Chapter hosted its Leadership Talk & Networking Event on 8 August 2026 at Radha Regent, Chennai, bringing together members and finance professionals for a morning filled with leadership insights, meaningful conversations and fresh perspectives. Led by Chapter Chair Chandrashekar Kupperi, the event was supported by the Chennai Chapter Board and its growing team of volunteers, reflecting the Chapter's continued focus on creating a stronger and more connected professional community. Setting the tone for the morning, Kupperi challenged the conventional idea of leadership. Drawing on the examples of Mahatma Gandhi and Nelson Mandela, he reminded the audience that neither held political office, yet both changed the world through moral authority. His three powerful messages - leadership is a practice, not a position; clarity over charisma; and conquer the mind before conquering the world - provided a thought-provoking foundation for the discussions that followed. The leadership conversation then moved from principle to lived experience with K. Pandiarajan, Founder of Ma Foi & CIEL HR and former Minister of Tamil Nadu. His remarkable journey, from working in a match factory as a child to building organisations, leading Ma Foi and serving on India's first GST Council, offered a powerful lesson in perseverance and ambition. His framework was simple: the past teaches perseverance, the present demands execution, and the future requires us to think bigger. He also encouraged youngsters to look beyond conventional career paths and view Chartered qualifications such as US CMA, US CPA and CA as platforms for entrepreneurship, leadership and creating wider impact.

CAMBRIDGE TECHNOLOGY ENTERPRISES LIMITED

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Email: cte_secretarial@ctepl.com **Website:** www.ctepl.com **CIN:** L72200TG1999PLC030997

UN-AUDITED CONSOLIDATED & STANDALONE FINANCIAL RESULTS FOR THE QUARTER ENDED JUNE 30 2026

We wish to inform that the Board of Directors of the Company at its meeting held on Friday, August 14 2026 has inter-alia considered and approved the Un-Audited Financial Results (Standalone and consolidated) of the Company for the quarter ended June 30, 2026. Please scan below Quick Response (QR) Code where complete financial results of the listed entity, as specified in regulation 33 of SEBI (LODR) Regulations, 2015, along with the declaration of unmodified opinion, is accessible to the investors. The said Financial Results are also available on the websites of the Stock Exchange(s) at www.bseindia.com and www.nseindia.com and the Company's web page at https://www.ctepl.com/investors/.

For financial results, scan QR code below:

For Cambridge Technology Enterprises Limited
Sd/-
Raj Kumar Sehgal
Whole – Time Director and CFO
(DIN: 01570858)

Place: Hyderabad
Date: August 14, 2026

KINGFA SCIENCE & TECHNOLOGY (INDIA) LIMITED

CIN : L25209TN1983PLC010438
Regd. Office : Dhun Building, III Floor, 827, Anna Salai, Chennai - 600 002.
Phone : 044 - 28521736 | **Fax :** 044 - 28520420 | **E-mail :** cs@kingfaindia.com | **Website :** www.kingfaindia.com

UNAUDITED FINANCIAL RESULTS FOR THE QUARTER ENDED JUNE 30, 2026

The Board of Directors of the Company at its meeting held on August 14, 2026, has approved the unaudited financial results of the Company prepared in accordance with Indian Accounting Standards for the quarter ended June 30, 2026.

The full format of the financial results are available on the websites of the Stock exchanges where shares of the Company are listed i.e., www.bseindia.com and www.nseindia.com and also on the website of the Company i.e. www.kingfaindia.com and can be accessed by scanning the below QR Code.

Scan the QR Code to view the Results on the website of the company

For Kingfa Science & Technology (India) Limited
Sd/-
Deepak Vyas
Company Secretary

Place: Pune
Date: 14/08/2026

KS SMART TECHNOLOGIES LIMITED

(Formerly known as SOMA PAPERS & INDUSTRIES LIMITED)
Regd Office: 528, Anna Salai, Teynampet, Chennai 600018.
Email: hello@ksstech.co | Website: www.ksstech.co
CIN: L62099TN1991PLC196352

EXTRACT OF CONSOLIDATED UNAUDITED FINANCIAL RESULTS FOR THE QUARTER AND PERIOD ENDED JUNE 30, 2026

INR in Lakhs except EPS

SR. NO.	Particulars	Quarter Ended		Year ended
		30-Jun-26	31-Mar-26	31-Mar-26
		(Reviewed)	(Audited)	(Audited)
1	Total Income from operations (net)	23,704.34	81,902.71	1,32,488.09
2	Net Profit / (Loss) for the period (before Tax, Exceptional and / or Extraordinary Items)	573.23	7,615.03	10,132.58
3	Net Profit / (Loss) for the period (before Tax and after Exceptional and / or Extraordinary Items)	573.23	7,615.03	10,132.58
4	Net Profit / (Loss) for the period (after Tax and after Exceptional and / or Extraordinary Items)	379.64	5,657.91	7,433.01
5	Total Comprehensive Income for the period [Comprising Profit / (Loss) for the period (after tax) and Other Comprehensive Income (after tax)]	380.92	5,663.69	7,438.10
6	Equity Share Capital	11,576.67	11,576.67	11,576.67
7	Reserves (excluding Revaluation Reserve) as shown in the Audited Balance Sheet of the previous year.	-	-	17,934.07
8	Earnings per Share for continued and discontinued operations (in INR)			
	(a) Basic	0.23	4.88	9.17
	(b) Diluted	0.23	4.88	9.17

Note:
1 The statements of unaudited financial results have been prepared in accordance with the applicable Indian Accounting standard notified under Section 133 of the Companies Act, 2013 {Indian Accounting Standard} Rules, 2015 (as amended) and other accounting principles generally accepted in India
2 The above results have been reviewed by the Audit Committee and approved by the Board of Directors at their respective meeting held on 14th August, 2026.
3 The Auditors of the company have carried out "Limited review" of the above financial results for the quarter ended 30th June, 2026.
4 The above is an extract of the detailed format of Period ended Results filed with the Stock Exchanges under Regulation 33 of the SEBI (Listing and Other Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015. The full format of the Financial Results are available on the websites of the Stock Exchange and the company's website

Place : Chennai
Date : 14-08-2026

For KS SMART TECHNOLOGIES LIMITED
(Formerly known as SOMA PAPERS & INDUSTRIES LIMITED)
SD/-
Keshav AS
MANAGING DIRECTOR
DIN:07863502

The results can be accessed the through the following link
https://ksstech.co/investors
or Scan

FISCHER MEDICAL VENTURES LIMITED

CIN: L86900AP1993PLC118162
Regd Off: No.480/2, AMTZ , Nadapura Village, Pedagantyada Mandal, Vishakapatnam, Visakhapatnam, Andhra Pradesh- 530044
Corp Off: Level 8, Prestige Palladium Bayan, No. 129-140 Greams Road, Chennai, Tamil Nadu, 600006, India
Email: cs@fischermv.com | Website: www.fischermv.com

EXTRACT OF THE STANDALONE AND CONSOLIDATED UNAUDITED FINANCIAL RESULTS FOR THE QUARTER ENDED 30.06.2026 PURSUANT TO REGULATION 47 OF SEBI (LODR) REGULATIONS, 2015.

(Rs.in Lakhs except per share data)

S. No.	PARTICULARS	STANDALONE				CONSOLIDATED			
		Quarter Ended			Year Ended	Quarter Ended			Year Ended
		30.06.2026	31.03.2026	30.06.2025	31.03.2026	30.06.2026	31.03.2026	30.06.2025	31.03.2026
		(Unaudited)	(Audited)	(Unaudited)	(Audited)	(Unaudited)	(Audited)	(Unaudited)	(Audited)
1.	Total Income	161.23	454.16	534.63	2,088.52	8,340.43	9,830.62	3,091.11	32,088.93
2.	Net Profit / (Loss) for the period before Tax, Exceptional and Extraordinary items	(322.99)	(1,016.68)	(21.56)	(1,050.58)	783.21	(757.11)	1,013.87	4,658.38
3.	Net Profit / (Loss) for the period before tax [after Exceptional and Extraordinary items]	(322.99)	(1,016.68)	(21.56)	(1,050.58)	783.21	(758.19)	1,002.72	4,636.19
4.	Net Profit / (Loss) for the period after tax, Exceptional and Extraordinary items	(350.41)	(898.18)	(60.94)	(1,042.29)	379.13	(1,243.74)	486.01	3,101.95
5.	Profit / (Loss) from Discontinued Operations	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–
6.	Other Comprehensive Income	–	–	–	–	–	(0.89)	–	5.43
7.	Total Comprehensive Income For The Period [Comprising Profit / (Loss) For The Period (After Tax) And Other Comprehensive Income For The Period (After Tax)]	(350.41)	(898.18)	(60.94)	(1,042.29)	379.13	(1,244.63)	486.01	3,107.38
8.	Equity Share Capital (F.V. Rs.1/- per share)	**6,545.15**	**6,545.15**	**6,485.15**	**6,545.15**	**6,545.15**	**6,545.15**	**6,485.15**	**6,545.15**
9.	Reserves [Excluding Revaluation Reserves] as shown in the Audited Balance Sheet				24,684.13				29,309.40
10.	Earnings per share								
	- Basic Continuing Operations	(0.05)	(0.14)	(0.01)	(0.16)	0.06	(0.19)	0.08	0.47
	- Diluted from Continuing Operations	(0.05)	(0.13)	(0.01)	(0.15)	0.05	(0.18)	0.07	0.44
	- Basic from Discontinuing Operations	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–
	- Diluted from Discontinued Operations	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–
	- Basic from Continuing and Discontinued Operations	(0.05)	(0.14)	(0.01)	(0.16)	0.06	(0.19)	0.08	0.47
	- Diluted from Continuing and Discontinued Operations	(0.05)	(0.13)	(0.01)	(0.15)	0.05	(0.18)	0.07	0.44

Note:
The above is an extract of the detailed format of Quarterly UnAudited Standalone and Consolidated Financial Results filed with the Stock Exchanges under Regulation 33 of the SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015. The full format of the Quarterly Unaudited Standalone and Consolidated Financial Results are available on the Stock Exchange websites (www.nseindia.com and www.bseindia.com) and on the Company's website : www.fischermv.com

Date: 14.08.2026

// By Order of the Board //

Sd/-
Managing Director

XELPMOC DESIGN AND TECH LIMITED

CIN: L72200KA2015PLC082873
Registered Office: No.57, 13th Cross, Novel Business Park, Hosur Road, Anepalya, Adugodi, Bengaluru - 560030, Karnataka, India. **Tel. No:** (+91) 6364316889;
E-mail: vaishali.kondbhar@xelpmoc.in; **Website:** www.xelpmoc.in

Statement of unaudited standalone and consolidated financial results for the quarter ended June 30, 2026

(Rupees in 1000's except per share data)

Sl. No.	Particulars	Standalone				Consolidated			
		Quarter ended	Quarter ended	Quarter ended	Year ended	Quarter ended	Quarter ended	Quarter ended	Year ended
		June 30, 2026	March 31, 2026	June 30, 2025	March 31, 2026	June 30, 2026	March 31, 2026	June 30, 2025	March 31, 2026
		(Unaudited)	(Unaudited)	(Unaudited)	(Audited)	(Unaudited)	(Unaudited)	(Unaudited)	(Audited)
1	Income from operations	9,615.70	10,791.35	7,849.94	37,353.38	9,615.70	10,791.35	7,849.94	37,353.38
2	Net profit / (Loss) for the period (before Tax, Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)	(17,779.47)	(18,299.26)	(17,764.39)	(72,895.84)	(17,975.21)	(18,486.19)	(18,862.31)	(74,634.66)
3	Net profit / (Loss) for the period before tax (after Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)	(17,779.47)	(18,299.26)	(17,764.39)	(75,676.59)	(17,975.21)	(18,486.19)	(18,862.31)	(77,415.41)
4	Net profit / (Loss) for the period after tax (after Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)	(21,848.67)	(17,604.59)	(17,721.18)	(74,188.95)	(22,044.41)	(17,791.52)	(18,819.10)	(75,927.78)
5	Total Comprehensive Income for the period [Comprising Net profit / (Loss) for the period (after tax) and Other Comprehensive Income (after tax)]	(21,848.67)	(17,604.59)	(30,719.34)	100,529.83	(22,044.41)	(5,446.67)	(31,817.26)	98,791.00
6	Equity share capital	147,994.93	147,594.93	147,594.93	147,594.93	147,994.93	147,594.93	147,594.93	147,594.93
7	Reserves excluding revaluation reserves as per the balance sheet of the previous year				596,584.07				600,517.66
8	Earnings per share of (Rs. 10 each) **								
	a) Basic (Rs.)	(1.48)	(1.19)	(1.20)	(5.03)	(1.49)	(1.21)	(1.28)	(5.15)
	b) Diluted (Rs.)	(1.45)	(1.17)	(1.19)	(4.93)	(1.46)	(1.18)	(1.26)	(5.05)

** EPS not annualised for quarter ended June 30, 2026, March 31, 2026 and June 30, 2025.

1. The above is an extract of the detailed format of Quarter ended June 30, 2026, Financial Results filed with the Stock Exchanges under Regulation 33 of the SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015. The full format of the Quarterly Financial Results is available on the websites of the Stock Exchange(s) www.bseindia.com & www.nseindia.com and on the website of the Company www.xelpmoc.in under Investor Relation Section.
2. The Audit Committee has reviewed, and the Board of Directors has approved the above Results and its release at their respective meetings held on August 14, 2026.

For and on behalf of the board of directors of
Xelpmoc Design and Tech Limited
sd/-
Srinivas Koora
Whole Time Director and Chief Financial Officer
DIN: 07227584

Place: Hyderabad
Date: August 14, 2026

CONCEPT

JINDAL POLY FILMS LIMITED

CIN :- L17111UP1974PLC003979
Regd. Office : 19th K.M., Hapur Bulandshahr Road, P.O. Gulaothi, Bulandshahr (U.P.) 245408.
Corporate. Office : Plot Number - 12, Sector B1, Local Shopping Complex, Vasant Kunj, New Delhi – 110070.

Statement of Unaudited Financial Results For the Quarter ended June 30, 2026

Rs in Lakhs except EPS — Rs in Lakhs except EPS

Consolidated				Particulars	Standalone			
Quarter Ended			Year Ended		Quarter Ended			Year Ended
June 30, 2026 (Unaudited)	March 31, 2026 (Audited)	June 30, 2025 (Unaudited)	March 31, 2026 (Audited)		June 30, 2026 (Unaudited)	March 31, 2026 (Audited)	June 30, 2025 (Unaudited)	March 31, 2026 (Audited)
69,579.62	67,462.95	1,08,340.69	2,89,942.05	Total Income from Operations	19,071.28	16,814.66	16,980.63	69,739.09
10,660.06	(29,182.32)	5,953.83	(33,699.50)	Net Profit for the period (before Tax, Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items) from continuing and discontinued operations	14,870.92	(13,337.43)	11,485.20	6,102.88
10,660.06	(1,35,674.63)	5,953.83	(1,40,410.13)	Net Profit/ (Loss) for the period before Tax (after Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items) from continuing and discontinued operations	(7,479.08)	(2,24,024.51)	11,485.20	(2,08,612.80)
10,719.71	(98,808.23)	3,650.61	(1,06,189.36)	Net Profit / (Loss) for the period after Tax (after Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items) from continuing and discontinued operations	(9,497.23)	(2,18,008.34)	9,260.08	(2,02,714.57)
10,506.63	(97,962.36)	5,369.84	(1,01,891.21)	Total Comprehensive Income for the period (Comprising Profit / (Loss) for the period (after Tax) and Other Comprehensive Income (after Tax)) from continuing and discontinued operations	(9,497.23)	(2,18,018.08)	9,260.08	(2,02,702.67)
4,378.64	4,378.64	4,378.64	4,378.64	Equity Share Capital (Face Value of Rs 10/- each)	4,378.64	4,378.64	4,378.64	4,378.64
		-	3,00,695.97	Reserves (excluding revaluation reserve) as shown in the Audited Balance Sheet of the previous year		4,04,948.83		4,04,948.83
24.48	(225.66)	8.34	(242.52)	Basic & Diluted Earnings / (Loss) Per Share	(21.69)	(497.89)	21.15	(462.96)

Notes
1 Financial Results has been prepared in accordance with the Indian Accounting Standards ("Ind AS") prescribed under section 133 of the Companies Act 2013 read with the relevant rules issued thereunder.
2 The Financial Results were reviewed by the Audit Committee and taken on record at the meeting of the Board of Directors at their respective meetings held on Aug 14, 2026 and Limited Review of these results has been carried out by the Statutory Auditors of the Company.
3 The above is an extract of the detailed format of Unaudited Standalone and Consolidated Financial Results filed with the Stock Exchanges under Regulation 33 of the SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015. The full format of the Quarterly Unaudited Standalone and Consolidated Financial Results are available on the Stock Exchange websites (www.bseindia.com and www.nseindia.com) and also on the Company's website at www.jindalpoly.com.
4 Prevoius year figures have been regroup/rearranged whereever necessary.
5 "Details of Statutory Auditor's opinion given in the limited review report on unaudited Consolidated Financial Results for the Quater ended 30th June 2026. We draw attention to Note no. 4 to the accompanying financial results, which describes that consequent to the fire at the factory premises of a subsidiary at Nashik, Maharashtra on May 21, 2025, in the previous year the management of the subsidiary company along with surveyor has done physical verification of inventory and consequently the subsidiary -management has determined inventory damaged due to fire and accordingly have written off such inventory in the books of accounts of subsidiary company in the previous year. However, due to the fire some areas of the factory premises were affected and rebuilding work was in progress leading to storage space constraint and hence some of the inventories of usable waste which was not affected by fire was stored in a mixed condition. Owing to the above circumstances, at the year-end we could not perform and observe physical verification of the inventories. Subsequent to year end, a third party engaged by the management of the subsidiary company has performed physical verification of inventory but not for all items and in some cases quantities were arrived through a method of estimation. We are also the auditors of the subsidiary company and have performed alternative procedures, including verification of the subsequent movement of inventories, examination of quantitative records and other related documentation, which provided us with evidence in respect of the existence of such inventories. However, since we were not able to perform physical verification at year end March 31, 2026 and to date hence there could be excesses or shortages, if any, in the quantities which can only be determined when physical verification is performed and observed by us in the future periods. We were therefore unable to determine whether any adjustments were necessary to the carrying value of inventories amounting Rs. 27,135.62 Lakhs of the subsidiary as at June 30, 2026, and the consequential impact, if any, on the profit for the period, other equity and the related disclosures in the financial results of the Group."

For More Information Please Scan:

For and on behalf of the Board of Directors
For Jindal Poly Films Limited
Sd/-
Vijender Kumar Singhal
Whole Time Director & CFO
DIN - 09763670

Place : New Delhi
Date : 14 August 2026

US-IRAN DEADLOCK CONTINUES ON TALKS

Will declare Strait of Hormuz a territory of US, says Trump

Iran: Blockade to continue unless US accepts defeat

AGENCIES
Washington, August 15

STRAIT OF CONFLICT

■ Iran and Oman edging closer to a deal on how the Strait of Hormuz should be managed, agreeing on routes through the key waterway

■ Trump and Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent each pledged to inflict more financial damage on Iran

EVEN AS IRAN called on the US to accept defeat on Saturday, President Donald Trump blasted Tehran as "very evil" and said "will be declaring the Hormuz Strait a territory of the United States" in a political rally. Progress towards peace talks and oil tanker traffic through the strategic Strait of Hormuz remained halted, with no sign the warring parties were moving toward ending the conflict that the US and Israel launched on February 28.

"This strait will be opened and closed only under Iran's command, and so long as you do not accept the reality of defeat and stop indulging in fantasies, Iran will continue to enforce the blockade," Iran's Deputy Foreign Minister Kazem Gharibabadi posted on X. Foreign Minister Abbas Araqchi said Iran had not decided to resume talks with the US. He told Iranian news outlet *Shahrara News* in an interview published on Saturday that Washington must meet conditions on the strait in order for shipping to resume in the waterway that handled one-fifth of the world's oil before the war. As per a *Bloomberg News* report on Saturday, Iran and Oman appear to be edging closer to a deal on how the Strait of Hormuz should be managed, agreeing on routes through the key waterway. It added that the finalisation of a "shipping map" forms part of a broader accord to govern traffic through the strait and constitutes an independent arrangement between the two states that will uphold their sovereignty and ensure the safe transit of vessels.

At a rally in Garden City, New York, Trump urged Americans to accept slightly higher gasoline prices while the conflict continues. He said paying "a tiny little bit more for your gasoline" is worth the cost of ensuring "a very evil country" could not have a nuclear weapon. "What we're doing is a great service for the world, not only for ourselves ... and we're really doing a great job," Trump said. In a trend that has sparked inflation and disappointed voters, the average US price of a gallon of gasoline was about $4.08 on Friday, up 29% from a year earlier, according to the American Automobile Association.

Tehran, too, has stepped up its rhetoric in recent days as attempts to bring a permanent end to the war appear deadlocked. "The Strait of Hormuz cannot be seized by a tweet or an aircraft carrier, by issuing an order or by delivering an election speech," Gharibabadi said.

Trump and Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent each pledged to inflict more financial damage on Iran, with announcements of more measures against Iran were coming next week.

Only two vessels passed through the Strait of Hormuz on Friday with no crude oil shipments visible, as per an analysis by Kpler. Some ships may cross the strait undetected with their transponders off, but the figures are nowhere near the more than 130 ships that traversed daily before the war. Vessels that dare navigate the strait without permission risk strikes.

The UAE accused Iran of attacking a third vessel operated by Abu Dhabi National Oil Company that was transiting the strait on Friday, the Emirati state news agency *WAM* reported, after blaming it for two other incidents involving ADNOC vessels in the strait on Thursday evening.

Alibaba AI models beat Meta, Google downloads

BLOOMBERG
August 15

ALIBABA GROUP HOLDING'S open-weight models have accumulated more than 3 billion global downloads in the past six months, eclipsing Meta Platforms, Alphabet and domestic peers to become the world's No. 1 artificial-intelligence model.

Qwen, Alibaba's family of AI models, has open-sourced more than 460 models and its ecosystem has spawned 300,000-plus derivatives, the Chinese technology company said in an emailed statement. Google, part of Alphabet, had 418 million downloads while Meta stood at 227 million in 2026, according to popular open-source AI hub Hugging Face, which published a state of open models report on August 14. Open models can be downloaded, customised and used as building blocks for new AI products, making adoption a gauge of which technologies developers are choosing to build on. That has made download and derivative-model figures one measure of influence in the US-China AI race, as Chinese developers including Alibaba push capable models that are relatively cheap and easy to adapt. Qwen's rise suggests that strategy is gaining traction beyond China.

AT LEAST 47 DEAD IN INDONESIAN QUAKES

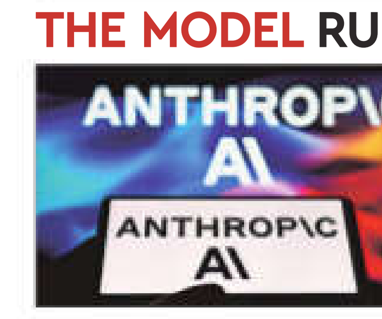
A magnitude 7.7 earthquake and dozens of aftershocks struck Flores island in eastern Indonesia on Saturday. Preliminary data showed 157 homes were heavily damaged. About 13 hours later, a 6.9 magnitude quake jolted Pematangsiantar in north Sumatra province AP

Anthropic revenue surges to over $11.5 bn in 2nd quarter

Wall St projecting 2028 revenue of $190 bn-$200 bn

AGENCIES
Washington, August 15

THE MODEL RUN



■ Company's revenue was $787 mn in Q2 of 2025, $4.73 bn in Q1 of 2026

■ Anthropic is meeting with investors ahead of mega-IPO this fall

ANTHROPIC IS TELLING prospective investors its second-quarter revenue jumped at least 14-fold versus the same period a year ago, according to documents seen by *Bloomberg News*.

The Claude chatbot maker reported a preliminary revenue figure of more than $11.5 billion in its latest completed quarter, compared to $787 million in the corresponding period in 2025, and $4.73 billion in the first quarter of this year. The second quarter of 2026 saw Anthropic report positive adjusted operating income. Deliberations are ongoing and the figures could be revised. The rapid growth comes as the company battles its longtime rival OpenAI to win over corporate customers. Anthropic has seen a surge in professionals adopting its software. The company is meeting with investors ahead of its potential mega-IPO this fall, people familiar with the matter said in July. Anthropic filed confidentially for a listing, and is working with Morgan Stanley, Goldman Sachs Group and JPMorgan Chase on the IPO, *Bloomberg News* has reported.

Wall Street is looking further into the future to put a price on the AI company, valuing it based on how much revenue it could generate two years from now, *Reuters* reported. Anthropic is projecting 2028 revenue of $190 billion to $200 billion, according to two people familiar with the company's financials, a figure that has not previously been reported.

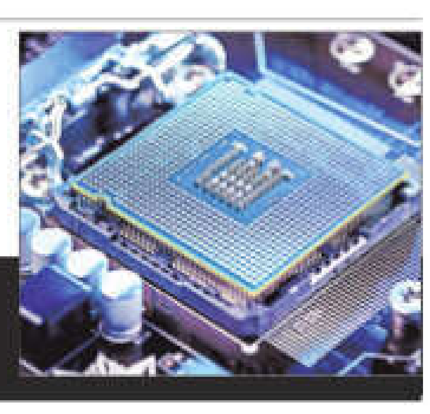
Must pick sides in AI race with China: US to tell allies

REUTERS
Washington, August 15

AI FRAMEWORK

■ Pax Silica initiative aims to secure supply chains for AI models, semiconductors and critical minerals

■ About two dozen countries have joined the US initiative



THE US IS preparing to tell dozens of countries they must pick sides in the artificial intelligence race with China, warning they will be excluded from a US-led AI coalition if they also sign up for Beijing's competing framework, according to a US official and an internal draft reviewed by *Reuters*.

Washington last year launched the Pax Silica initiative aimed at securing supply chains for AI models, semiconductors and critical minerals, amid a fierce technology rivalry with Beijing. About two dozen countries have joined, including allies such as Japan, Australia, South Korea and Kazakhstan. The draft letter, prepared by the State Department, is addressed to the 35 signatories of a US "AI Opportunity Statement" signed in June, which includes members of the non-binding Pax Silica framework and other countries that have expressed a desire to align cooperation with Washington.

The US has also urged Apple not to buy Chinese memory chips, the *WSJ* reported. In July, Chinese President Xi Jinping launched a rival "World Artificial Intelligence Cooperation Organization", promoting his country's open-weight technology as a challenge to US influence. Kazakhstan is the only country known to have joined both initiatives.

"To be part of everything is to be part of nothing. Signature of the Pax Silica Declaration is not merely a membership subscription, but a commitment," the letter says, urging countries to "choose deliberately" on artificial intelligence.